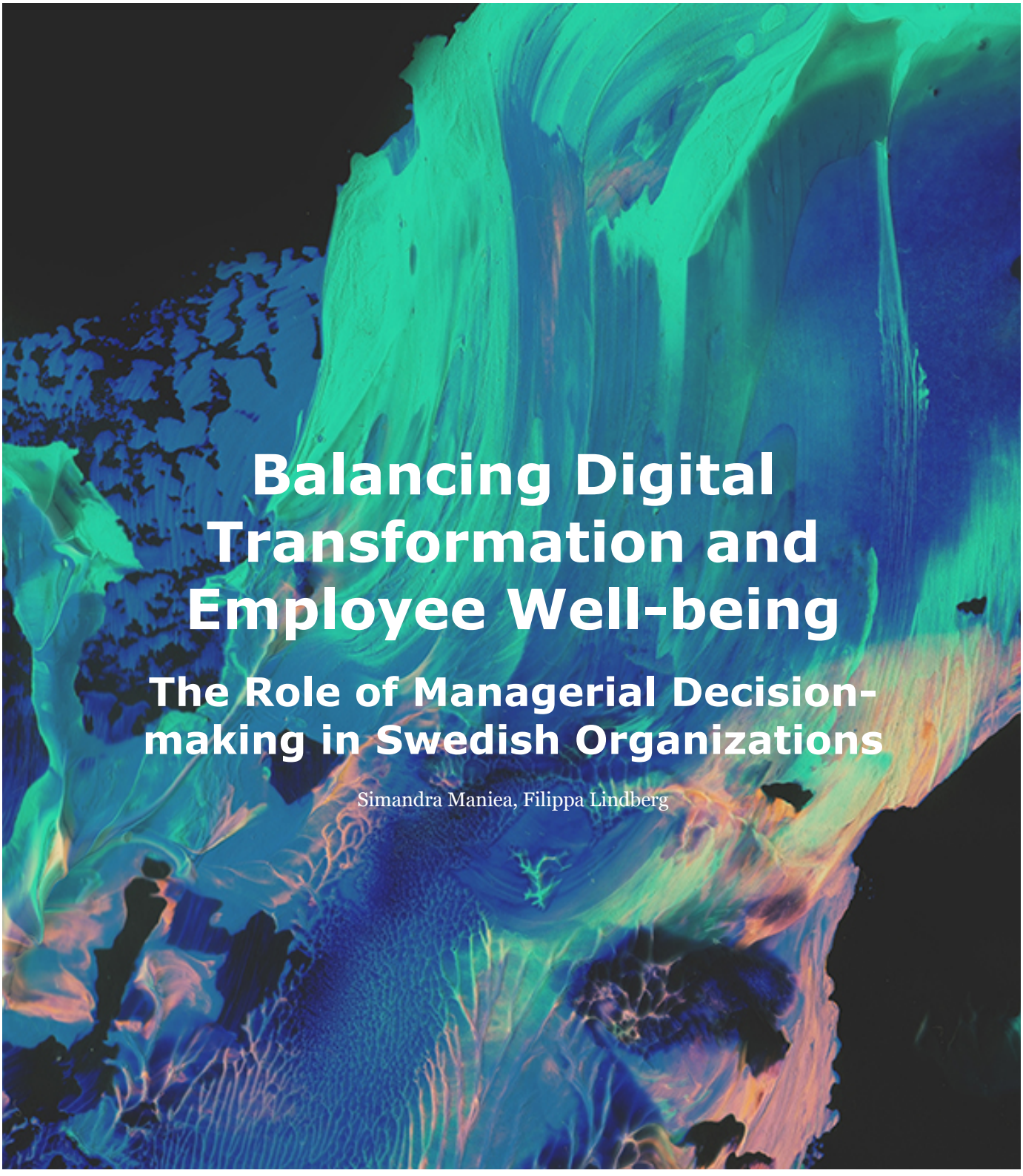
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Balancing Digital Transformation and Employee Well-being

The Role of Managerial Decision-making in Swedish Organizations

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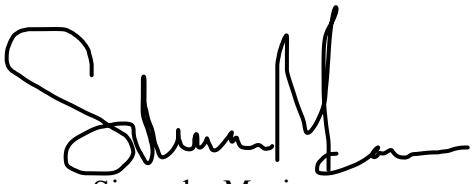
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Abstract

Digital transformation is reshaping organizational conditions and altering how managerial decision-making is carried out. This study investigates how managerial decision-making during digital transformation affects employee well-being with a focus on employee motivation, job satisfaction, and performance, in Swedish organizations. Theories about decision-making, digital transformation, and employee well-being acted as central frameworks in this study to gather an increased understanding of how the components relate to each other. This study used a qualitative research design with semi-structured interviews, where nine interviews was conducted with perspectives from experts, managers, and employees from five large organizations within the business sector to further explore how digitalization is implemented in practice and how these dimensions influence employee well-being. The material was analyzed using a thematic analysis to capture how digitalization is implemented in practice and how managerial choices shape employee experiences of the transformation.

The findings indicate that digital transformation is not merely a technological shift but a thorough process that requires evaluated implementation strategy that is continuously revised to align with the organizational goals and maintain employee well-being. Factors as communication, proper training, and guidance help increase successful digitalized implementation. Managers act as intermediaries, shaping the acceptance of digital tools and helping maintain employee well-being. Employee motivation, job satisfaction, and ultimately employee performance was found to increase when employees perceived adequate support, competence development, and opportunities to learn. This study contributes to the literature by demonstrating that managerial decision-making functions as a mechanism through which digital transformation affects employee well-being. It provides empirical insights in the Swedish organizational context, addressing a current gap in previous research. Finally, the study provides practical and theoretical insights into how digital transformation can be implemented in ways that improve employee well-being whilst ensuring a successful and effective implementation strategy process. Lastly, a recommendation for future research is highlighted as this study gives an academic contribution in which future research can develop further.

Key words: Digital transformation, implementation strategy, managerial decision-making, employee well-being, employee motivation, job satisfaction, employee performance, Swedish organizations

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1. Introduction

In this chapter lies the introduction for this thesis. The chapter include background, research gap, research purpose, problem discussion, delimitations, and definitions of the study. It begins with an explementary background about digital transformation and its effect on decision-making, organizational structure and employee well-being. These components contribute to identifying the research gap from which the research question and research purpose emerged.

1.1 Background

Digital transformation is increasing all over the world and it has been proven to have a positive effect on companies' productivity (Li et al., 2024, p. 28). This makes it crucial for corporate survival whether they adapt and develop digital tools that include artificial intelligence (AI), business systems, automatization etc. or not, making managers decision-making different from the traditional way. Mikalef et al. (2019, p. 273) means that companies are in strong need to combine technological, human, financial, and intangible resources to guide preferable decision-making for managers.

Furthermore, managers play a significant role in the implementation of digitalized tools in the workplace and their effectiveness of the organization. Moreover, how managers integrate such technologies, in their decision-making. The process of choosing between two or more alternatives to determine the optimal outcome for achieving a long-term goal is what traditional decision-making is defined as (Voskoglou, 2024, p. 136). The author (2024) further states that before the development of technology, managers relied on intuition, skills, and previous experience to calculate a decision. Since the raising of technology, it has enabled a redefinition of how managers approach decision-making (Rivero, 2025, p. 34). Instead of relying on human capabilities to make a well-defined decision, the process of decision-making is now addressed differently. Using digital tools can help managers analyze and predict real time data as well as future actions that will lead to proactive strategies rather than reactive ones (Rivero, 2025, p. 34). On the other hand, overusing digital tools in the decision-making process can lead to relying too much on technology and disintegrate human judgment which reduces the human capability to question and analyze the generated results (Mason & Nightingale, 2026, p. 8-9).

Additionally, it is of importance to acknowledge managers' level of comprehension for AI as a digital tool as it is another factor that plays a crucial part in a digital transformation. Managers need to be prepared for such transition and are required to adapt both psychologically and behaviorally to the transition (Yang et al., 2024, p. 4). To acquire a successful and accepted implementation of digital tools to the organization, managers attitudes, beliefs and readiness regarding the subject is some of the attributes that are needed to possess (Yang et al., 2024). Managers do also possess the power to somewhat control the outcome of how the organization reacts to the implementation by protecting the organizations' interest whilst the same encourages digital choices (Zhang & Jin, 2023, p. 5). Additionally, managers' behavior towards digital transformation can positively influence how the organization approaches the change, thus making beneficial long-term decision-making for the company (Zhang & Jin, 2023, p. 17). To ensure that the implementation of digital tools goes smoothly and is successful, managers have the potential to do so from how their attitude is.

All over the world, most industries are developing and integrating technology to make work more efficient, which is described by “The 4.0 Industrial Revolution” where the technology is being used in everyday work and life (Stamate et al., 2021). AI is one of the technologies that is supposed to imitate the intelligence of human beings, only working more efficiently and effectively, and adapt the skills of problem solving, planning, reasoning among others which further assists organizations in decision-making (Phuoc, 2022). SCB (2025) a Swedish state agency responsible for official statistics states that AI is being used progressively amongst corporate specifically in information- and communications industries where 71,9 precent of the companies have used AI in one or more specific purposes, focusing on marketing and sales purposes. The statistics show that 11,1 percent of those who did not use AI are in fact considering implementing it and the main reason for not executing it earlier is because of lack of knowledge of relevance (SCB, 2025). It is believed that AI can have alarming consequences on workers thus the importance of developing it with human beings and the workers' well-being in mind (Stamate et al., 2021).

The rise of AI and digitalization overall has transformed how business operates in many ways; one is how employees are impacted by it in the workplace and whether or not humans are being replaced by machines. Stamate et al. (2021) discusses the fact that AI, as a digital tool, is not necessarily a replacement of humans as it, depending on the usage, can either be positive or negative on the well-being of workers. An impacting factor influencing how coworkers in companies react to the implementation of digitalization is status threat, as it arises the fear of some employees losing their status and for others not being able to improve it (SimanTov-Nachlieli, 2024, p. 15). Grundke (2024, p. 1349) argues that humans feel a threatening to their status as AI are being developed to think and act more like the human brain and are introduced as a co-worker in the work setting which leads to a decrease in employees' performance. On the other hand, employees can thrive and grow in corporate environments when there is managerial support during the digital transformation era and with the right decision-making, employees grow their emotional attachment and performance to the organization (Qiao, 2024, p. 12). Additionally, employees can use AI to foresee opportunities that align with personal competences to increase motivation, which leads to higher performance while managers play a key role in fostering this type of supportive environment (Tahir et al., 2024, p. 1123).

In regard of the different impacts on digital transformations affect on employees' wellbeing and the fact that managers play a key role in the implementation as a tool to decision-making, this topic is of high relevance to organizations and managers entering the digital world.

1.2 Research gap

In the business sector, the traditional way of looking at decision-making regards human experience, emotional stakes, and a limited rationality (Guan et al., 2022, p. 1). With the digital transformation, an incorporated decision-making process with AI as a tool is on the other hand based on data analysis and learning algorithms (Guan et al., 2022, p. 1). The increasing means of usage of digital technologies has provided a shift in the decision-making process, therefore becoming more reliant on data-driven decisions (Shalu et al., 2025, p. 74). Thus, affecting how managers make decisions and their influence in a rapid technological change. Whilst previous theoretical frameworks that are built on the traditional view of leadership are being questioned, new approaches are needed to explain

the impact of digitalization on leadership (Cortellazo et al., 2019, p. 15). According to the authors (2019, p. 17) there is a shortage of knowledge in the combination of leadership and digital transition which is supported by Weber et al. (2022, p. 16) that brings up the gap in research between leadership and digital transformation. This highlights a significant lack of integration were studying the relationship between the new digital way to make decisions and how managers lead in this matter is needed.

Managers are highlighted as key players in decision-making processes and an important aspect to consider when implementing digital transitions (Yang et al., 2024, p. 2). Managers act as a means to smooth transitions of new tasks and processes and can ease the transition of implementing new technological aspects (Yang et al., 2024, p. 4). While this clarifies managers' decision-making process in relation to digital transformation, there is still a big gap in research when it comes to practical insights as most research is theoretical (Li, 2020, p. 815). The author (2020, p. 815) suggests future research to do a qualitative study and explore the relation between strategy and execution in a digital context. Additionally, it does not add to the perspective of employees or what affects decision-making in digital transformation might have on motivation, performance, and job satisfaction. Chiva et al. (2007, p. 239) points out that more research is needed to increase understanding in the relationship between organizational learning capability and employee job satisfaction, emotional intelligence as well as commitment on an organizational level. This creates a strong need to research further on the relation these three variables have to each other, if they relate and what effect might occur.

Digital transformation is an organizational change that has arisen because of the increase of digital technologies (Yang, 2024, p. 1). AI is a technology considered a highly fast-paced, ever-changing technical field. Research highlights that there is a continuous need for further development in the area regarding this technology (Cramarenco et al., 2023, p. 747). AI is highly complex and will have an impact on the future labor market. This includes the structure of work procedures, task design, and job requirements (Cramarenco et al., 2023, p. 747). Stamante et al. (2021, p. 951) adds further the need to understand the conceptual effects of AI as a tool on individuals. Further, it is highlighted by research that the need for an increased understanding of managerial challenges when applying AI technology in different types of decision-making (Chaturvedi et al., 2025, p. 12 317). These claims a need for a broader understanding of how digital technologies affect the employee's wellbeing and possible complexity that follows with it, as well as how manager ensures an existence of both simultaneously.

To conclude from previous research, one can note a considerate gap in Nordic and specifically Swedish market in this topic. Most studies are done in China, India and UK (Chaturvedi, 2025; Yang, 2024; Guan et al., 2022). Therefore, this thesis also aims to look at corporate organizations from Sweden to try and add to the existing gap.

Based on this, one can see a clear pattern of shortage of information regarding decision-making in relation to managerial roles and their effect on employee well-being. Our research builds on the existing ones on digital transformation, adding and specifying on managers' decision-making perspective in the Swedish market.

1.3 Research question

From the previous section, it was derived that the increasing integration of digitalization has reshaped managerial work specifically on how they make decisions and lead to maintaining employee well-being. Making it is unclear how employee motivation, job

satisfaction, and performance integrate and are affected by managerial decision-making in digital transformation. This study suggests that there is a strong correlation between managers' support and employee outcome during digital implementation.

The gaps taken together highlight the need for research that explores how managerial decision-making in digital transformation influences employee well-being in an organizational setting. To address this gap, the following research question have been chosen:

"During digital transformation, how does managers' decision-making affect employee motivation, job satisfaction, and performance? "

1.4 Research purpose

The purpose of this thesis is to investigate how managers balance digital transformation and their employees' wellbeing, more specifically the usage of digital tools in decision-making, and if it has an influence on employee's motivation, performance and job-satisfaction. We want to explore the relation between how managers use digitalization when making decisions and further how they shape this digital transformation to have a positive outcome on the workers, to maintain their effectiveness and job satisfaction. As the research shows (Cramarenco et al., 2023), it is an undenied fact that digital technologies are and will be developed into more industries and can play a significant role in how businesses move forward. Therefore, we want to examine if, and how, managers work to maintain the organizational well-being where employees are supported and maintaining their motivation level and performance, and at the same time having a successful digital transformation in the decision-making process.

A focus on how organizations are taking steps toward digital transformation in decision-making will be shown throughout this thesis, since it is a highly attractive adaption that organizations all over are working on to understand. The focus will be in relation to how managers work with this digital transformation to ensure stability in job- performance and satisfaction. Additionally, in later years it has been proven that the process of decision-making is starting to look different now that AI as a digital tool has been implemented (Rivero, 2025). Furthermore, this creates an interesting standpoint for how managers balance the consequences of digitalization, both the good and the bad.

1.5 Problem discussion

As previously mentioned, the highly evolving field of digitalization is affecting how organizations make decisions. Organizations are facing a transition in decision-making towards a larger influence of data driven decisions. AI is being used by more organizations as a digital tool in the decision-making process (Chaturvedi et al., 2025, p. 12307*).* Leading to arguments that the integration of AI is to be associated with boosts in productivity and efficiency. More organizations point out the increase in performance when individuals collaborate with this digital tool as it creates more effective decisions (Chaturvedi et al., 2025, p. 12306-12307). Making decisions are associated with top-level executives (Chaturvedi et al., 2025, p. 12305) and are therefore a task expected to be handled by managers. The problem that emerges is that employees are therefore not factored in the decision-making process, and little research is shown on what digital transformation in decision making actually means for them. Van Der Schaft et al. (2024, p. 814) findings show that although employees can seem eager on digital transformation at first, it holds hidden risks in the long run. Many of the employees felt a false sense of

reality as the change was more challenging and uncertain than what they had been told (Van Der Schaft, 2024, p. 814-815). This creates a well identified problem that digital transformation has dual consequences for an organization. On one hand, it can help managers make well informed decisions for the benefit of the whole company, whilst on the other hand, digital transformation can also create failure in an organization and increase uncertainty which leads to a decrease in motivation and job satisfaction with the employee.

Further, managers have a crucial role in how the outcome of the digital transformation will play out. Managers are being stuck "in the middle", between adapting to the digitalization for the organizational overall performance and employee wellbeing, creating implications for managers on how to balance the two variables. Managers act as leaders and need to work towards improving employee's motivation and performance and encourage an innovational and digitalized culture to adapt to the transformation (Qiao et al., 2024, p. 6). Whilst the same, managers have the responsibility to act in an effective way to shape the organizations' digital development in decision making (Qiao et al., 2024, p. 3-4). It is inevitable for organizations to take part in digital transformation, as a way to survive and even get ahead in the digital age, all whilst the same knowing the negativity it can bring with it and how to approach it for a long-term solution.

Previous research (Yang et al., 2024) has shown the different components and the relation between managerial decision-making and digital transformation, while other researchers have stated how digital transformation can impact employee wellbeing (Cramarenco et al., 2023; Stamante et al., 2021). Nonetheless, none have studied these variables in one framework, how they relate to each other and what affects they may give. Additionally, the research that has been done is limited in Sweden as little to none have been made. For this, we would like to investigate how and if the managers balance the digital transformation when introducing it to the decision-making process without compromising employee's motivation, performance, and satisfaction for their job. With the results of this, we aim to help managers understand the importance of how digital transformation in decision-making can otherwise lead to a failed one, leading to resistance to adaption.

1.6 Delimitations

This section will analyze the studies delimitations. One of the delimitations in our thesis is our definition of the concept of employee wellbeing. The World Health Organization (WHO) defines wellbeing as "*Mental health is a state of mental wellbeing that enables people to cope with the stresses of life, realize their abilities, learn well and work well, and contribute to their community*" (WHO, 2026). The description initiates that mental health advocates for healthy wellbeing, which gives the person the confidence to handle life's curves (WHO, 2026). Ones being in this state of mind, one can deal with stresses of life, adapt to changes and uncertainty whilst being able to give their best performance. The concept itself is broad and covers multiple aspects of an individual's wellbeing, thus it is important for our thesis to delimitate the meaning. This study conceptualizes well-being as individuals' well-being, with a sole focus on motivation, performance, and job satisfaction. This will enable us to have a better understanding of whether managerial decisions in digital transformation have an impact on employees' motivation and performance at work, and their job satisfaction.

Digital transformation is further a central factor in this research, and it's a wide term that goes beyond digitalization and implementation of technological tools. Hanelt et al (2021, p. 1168) describes the term as digital systems that are incorporated in the organization.

We will not limit our thesis to a specific type or dimension of digital transformation, as we did not want to restrict companies based on what they have implemented and are working with. This approach is what hopefully will give us a more generalized outcome as we will aim to find patterns and not what specific tools have been used. Additionally, it gives us a wider range of companies to include. On the other hand, it led to the third delimitation of this study, the market and industry scope.

In this study, our research will be limited to have a focus on the Swedish market and large organizations within the business sector that have implemented digitalizing, with a focus on operational-level work. This excludes top management and therefore limits generalizability of the findings, meaning the results may not be transferable to other organizations or industry contexts. This delimitation is motivated by the aim of ensuring contextual consistency, differences in digital maturity, and the fact that management practices may differ across countries and organizational sizes.

1.7 Definitions

Digital transformation is defined by Feliciano-Cestero et al. (2023, p. 2) as immerse changes in an organization that are influenced by technology and digitalized processes that have an effect on economic activities. Therefore, all digital tools, technologies, and digitalization processes that an organization is working with.

Well-being, a definition by the World Health Organization "*Mental health is a state of mental wellbeing that enables people to cope with the stresses of life, realize their abilities, learn well and work well, and contribute to their community*" (WHO, 2026). In this thesis, we will narrow the focus from the broad overall definition of wellbeing into employees' perspectives and specifically their job satisfaction, performance, and motivation.

Digital transformation in decision-making will be defined as the new approach to decision making process in contrast to the traditional way (Rivero, 2025).

2. Theoretical background

The theoretical background provides a conceptual foundation for this study by outlining key theories relevant to understanding the research question. It begins by examining the complexity of decision-making followed by digital transformation implementation, with a focus on technology adoption and its influence on decision making. Subsequently, it explores employee well-being, specifically motivation, job satisfaction, and performance.

2.1 Decision-making

Digitalization has reshaped how organizations operate, especially how managers make decisions. The increase of digital tools in day-to-day operations makes it a necessity for managers to incorporate it into their decision-making process. This generates a shift in which managers operate; traditional decisions were based on managers' own individual experienced based experts. However, today's decision-making process demands a different interactive approach with heightened need for digital capabilities in management (Raisch & Krakowski, 2020, p. 30). Raisch & Krakowski (2020) explain decision-making as a combination between human judgment and algorithmic recommendation, further changing the view on managerial decision-making. Understanding how digitalization influences decision-making is therefore of the essence for analyzing its impact on managerial practices and employee well-being.

2.1.1 Decision-making before digital transformation

Decision-making before digital transformation was primarily grounded in human judgement, experience and intuition; managers relayed their personal expertise and knowledge to evaluate alternatives and determine the most suitable course of action. Understanding this baseline is essential for analyzing how digital tools have altered the foundation of managerial decision-making. To understand these dynamics which managers maneuver, it is essential to look at the limitations and conditions where managers make decisions. Further, it adds relevance to this study by increasing the understanding of how managers make decisions and how it can influence employee well-being. One of the most influential theoretical frameworks regarding decision-making was proposed by Simon (1955) which will provide us with a foundation for how decision-making can be constrained and how this could be translated into a digital context and further the impact on employee well-being.

Bounded rationality is a highly relevant term and explains the importance of human influence in decision-making (Giarlotta & Petralia, 2024, p. 327). Giarlotta & Petralia (2024, p. 327) explains that the first attempt to conceptualize the framework of bounded rationality was done by Simon (1955) and is a continues relevant concept that is always being developed further. The traditional view is the economic assumption the “economic man”, who is supposed to have good knowledge about his surroundings, knowing what he wants to achieve and what action is right and therefore gives the best possible outcome (Simon, 1955, p. 99). Simon (1955, p. 99-100) criticizes this idea and instead means that individuals are limited in both information and cognitive capability. Thus, affecting the individual as a decision-maker and leading to simplifying the reality (Simon, 1955, p. 100). Simon (1955) therefore suggests a new way of thinking regarding rationality that takes the limitation of the human mind into consideration.

According to Simon (1955, p. 101), rationality is not only affected by external factors such as the environment but also by internal factors. These include physiological and psychological limitations which explain the aspect of time and memory. Another constriction in internal factors is the need for simplifying. There is a large complexity in the world which is why an individual tries to make a situation easier (Simon, 1955, p. 101). Simon (1955, p. 104) therefore introduces how decisions are being simplified. The individual divides the outcome if it is satisfactory or unsatisfactory, which correlates with the aspiration levels. The aspiration levels explain as the level which is deemed acceptable (Simon, 1955, p. 105). Therefore, instead of evaluating all possible alternatives, the individual does it until the aspirational level feels achieved. These levels are not static but dynamic and can change depending on, for example how easy it is to find satisfactory alternatives. If this is perceived simple, the aspiration levels will rise compared to if it's challenging the aspiration levels will fall (Simon, 1955, p. 111). Further one can conclude that if the alternative information is satisfactory and the aspiration levels higher one would have more outcomes that would be qualified as good. Thus, if there are more possible satisfactory alternatives it can also be correlated to a more well-thought and thorough decision.

2.1.2 Decision-making in the digital world

In contrast, decision-making in the digital world is characterized by a shift toward data-driven analysis with algorithmic input. As digital tools and AI systems are integrated into organizations, managers increasingly rely on automated insights and data to drive their decisions. This transformation changes the traditional decision-making and also the expectations placed on managers who now need to balance both human assessments and digital recommendations. Exploring the new aspect of decision-making is therefore crucial for understanding how digital transformation reshapes managers' role and its effect on employee well-being.

Except for the challenges such as bounded rationality manager face, the new digital era brings new obstacles; digitalization is one of which. A quite important factor influencing managers' decision making is the adoption of AI. Yordanova and Hristozov (2025, p. 220) illuminate that many organizations mistreat AI, as it is used as a passive analytic tool instead of a more advanced, adaptable tool to make decisions. Managers often think of AI as a calculator rather than a smart assistant, which limits the use of it, or the tool does not reach its full protentional. When digitalizing decision making, AI can positively affect decision making process as it increases speed and quality, making it beneficial for organizational performance (Neiroukh et al., 2025, p. 3 516). It is therefore significant for decision makers to understand how digital systems, such as AI, can not only be implemented in the decision-making process, but also how to use them. This fundamental step can help organizations make faster and more quality-based decisions leading to greater organizational results (Neiroukh et al., 2025, p. 3 516). On the contrary, AI can be overused when making decisions leading to a collapse in human judgment where the decisionmaker relies heavily on technological sources instead of own judgement (Mason & Nightingale, 2026, p. 1). This can be of a negative effect due to stop questioning the generative results and still choose to follow despite it being wrong (Mason & Nightingale, 2026, p. 8-9). Depending on how AI is used, it can either be a good support digital system or weaken decisions.

Furthermore, Pittenger et al. (2023, p. 890) brings up the aspect of information overload since organizations today face decisions being made from digital data gathering. The

availability of a large sum of data has transitioned more support systems in decision-making, being made with the help of digital solutions. Because of the idea that most information is at the palm of the hand, managers face the challenge that they should be able to make an optimal decision fast (Pittenger et al., 2023, p. 890). However, Pittenger et al. (2023, p. 890) challenges the idea that more information should lead to more rational decisions. Managers who possess a large amount of quantitative data can lead to hindrance in the cognitive abilities and therefore difficulty when dealing with these types of problems (Pittenger et al., 2023, p. 892). Furthermore, more information does not have to be equivalent to better decisions.

In the context of digital transition, decision-making has become vastly complex. On one hand, digital tools generate a higher accessibility to information and analytic capabilities and could therefore work as a support for the managers overcoming idea of cognitive limitation. On the other hand, the high amount of available data brings new challenges such as overload and the need for rapid decisions (Pittenger et al., 2023, p. 890). Managers must navigate these new obstacles of how to balance human judgement and data-driven insights. Hence, digital transition might change how bounded rationality is viewed and further impact managers' decision-making. This new era ensures difficulties for managers to make sure the decisions they make are understandable and legitimate for both them and their employees.

2.2 Digital transformation implementation

Digital transformation implementation refers to the organizational processes through which new digital systems are introduced and adopted into daily work processes. Digital tools create value when they are actively used, and implementation becomes a critical phase that determines if technology is accepted or not. This section examines factors that influence how digital transformation is introduced and received within organizations and how this relates to employee well-being and acceptance to technology.

With new technology constantly being developed, it can be hard to know and understand what digitalized systems mean. Further, if these systems are not being used, they cannot contribute to the improvement of the organization, which can be an underlying factor to a user's acceptance or rejection to the implementation of the technology (Davis, 1989). To understand the impact digital transition has on employee well-being, one needs to understand how it is accepted and perceived by the users. Valtonen and Holopainen (2025) researched the main reasons for employee resistance to new technologies and how it is related to their well-being. Resistance to the digital transition could be seen across three levels, individual, organizational, and technological where the first mentioned referred to individual lack of awareness, understanding and desire to learn, amongst other (Valtonen & Holopainen, 2025, p. 48). The second level aimed at the failed digital implementation and lack of experts perspective in the subject which would affect how it was thought and communicated to the rest of the organization (Valtonen & Holopainen, 2025, p. 49-50). Lastly, the technological level referred to errors in the systems, not knowing how to use new systems which lead to poor use or even over usage (Valtonen & Holopainen, 2025, p. 50). These factors can be the underlying cause to why digital transformation is met with resistance, thus needing strategic planning and understanding of how to proceed forward. On the other hand, factors such as learning, communication, and participation were found to be effective in implementing a successful and accepted digitalization (Valtonen & Holopainen, 2025, p. 51).

Ullrich et al. (2023) adds to the idea of having engaged and active employees gives a far more successful digital transformation. When employers are involved in the implementation early on, informed of the purpose of it, and the systems are designed with the workers in mind, it is proven to increase their well-being and satisfactions (Ullrich et al., 2023, p. 38). This implies the significant employee involvement has on digital transformation and the effect organization communication and transparency have. However, managers must first understand what factors affect users' acceptance to technology and how this further can shape employee well-being. One model explaining the acceptance of technology is Davis's (1989) technological acceptance model (TAM) that reflects what is needed for a new technology to be used. The framework contributes relevance to this study as it helps explain why employees choose to accept or reject new digital technologies in the workplace. Since this thesis focuses on the effects digital transformation has on employee well-being, the TAM framework provides a clear and established understanding for user behavior.

2.2.1 Employee acceptance to technologies

Fred D. Davis (1989) explains two measurable variables that help determine users' acceptance. The following two are: *perceived usefulness and perceived ease of use* (Davis, 1989, p. 320). When new technology is being introduced, certain variables cause people to either reject or accept it. These variables become especially relevant in organizational settings where employees must adapt to digital transformation. We will now examen in depth what the two specific variables mean.

Perceived Usefulness, if a technology is believed to be useful and help improve an employee's job performance, then it is most likely that the employee will use it (Davis, 1989, p. 320). If this digital system is an enhancement to the employer's work and is perceived as an advantage, it increases the chance of them adapting a positive take to digitalization (Davis, 1989, p. 320).

Perceived ease of use, an individual is most likely to accept and use a new digital system if they believe the system does not take a lot of effort, i.e. ease of use (Davis, 1989, p. 320). The easier the system is and less time it takes to learn in as well as use, it creates a deeper understanding of what comes with using it which increases the likelihood for a user to accept it.

An employer's intention to use a technical digital tool relies firmly and mostly on how useful the system is for their work, whilst the factor of whether or not the system is easy to use, becomes secondary. Davis (1989, p. 333) means that although the user might find it hard to use a system, it becomes justifiable if the same system offers high usefulness. In contrast to this, no amount of ease of use will encourage the user to accept the digitalization if it is not perceived to contribute and add to their current work (Davis, 1989, p. 333-334).

TAM-framework insinuates that Perceived Usefulness and Perceived Ease of Use both lead to the user's attitude and behavior towards using the actual system (Davis et al., 1989, p. 985). Therefore, the more usefulness a worker obtains from the technological tool to develop their job performance, the higher motivation they proceed to have to learn and actually use it. When increased performance is at stake, employee motivation tends to rise, thus if a digital transformation is presented as a way to increase performance, it leads to higher employee acceptance (Zhou et al., 2025).

2.2.2 Organizational structure as a variable

Variables are classified as design characteristics, implementation process, and how it develops over time, and organizational structure (Davis et al., 1989, p. 984). These variables are what have an influence on users' beliefs about a system leading to how they perceive its usefulness and ease of use that later affects their intention to use, which ultimately leads to actual system use (Davis et al., 1989, p. 985-986). In relevance of this thesis, a focus will be on variables such as organizational structure and managers as influencers to accept digital transformation.

Enabling an organization to structure a proper solution on how an implementation of digital transformation accurses with acceptance and to effectives organizational work, is necessary. Brock and Khan (2017) point out the importance of organizational factors as a part of technological adoption and how it can shape the acceptance of a newly introduced digital tool. Organizational learning capability (OLC) is a concept defined as how organizations implement, develop, and learn to use digitalization through their organizational structure to enhance efficiency (Chiva et al., 2007; Brock and Khan, 2017, p. 9), and can be seen as an additional concept to TAM-framework (Brock and Khan, 2017, p. 2). OLC defines four conditions that need to be met for the efficiency to work; the following is presented:

1. Managerial commitment, 2. System perspective, 3. Openness and experimentation, and 4. Transfer and Integration (Brock and Khan, 2017, p. 9). The criteria's mean that having the support and commitment from managers whilst prospering an organizational culture about learning and sharing knowledge, and being open to test, experiment and advocate for continuous learning (Brock and Khan, 2017, p. 9) can therefore give a successful digital transformation. Chiva et al. (2007, p. 225) shows further that the environment an organization fosters to make learning possible is by encouraging participation, openness, and communication. Once this kind of structure is embodied in an organization, it enhances performance and adaptability (Chiva et al., 2007, p. 238) which can be the external variable influencing a user's perceived usefulness (U) and perceived ease of use (E). Further, organizational performance is proven to be strengthened when adopting OLC components in the implementation of digital transformation (Chiva and Alegra, 2008, p. 323).

2.2.3 Managers as an influencing variable

In addition to organizational structure, managers have a significant part in how an implementation and use of digitalization plays about. Managers who cautiously work with support, proper training, and clear communication display favorably in the outcome of technological acceptance and usage (Amoako-Gyampah and Salam, 2003). The authors (2003) build on TAM-framework and proceed to exhibit how top management have a direct linkage to users perceived- usefulness (U) and ease of use (E), therefore strengthening acceptance of technology. Communication is viewed as one of the strongest tools, through providing information and understanding about what the digital transformation will center on leads to attitude (A) and behavioral intention (BI) to use, thus accepting technology (Amoako-Gyampah and Salam, 2003, p. 742). Training is the other component leading to successful adoption due to employees building their own experience and knowledge of its usefulness and ease of use, which increases actual use of a system (Amoako-Gyampah and Salam, 2003, p. 742). Hsu et al. (2019) adds to the theory which top management support to incorporate technology openness is required.

Organizations can predict and explain to what extent employers accept the new introduced technology (Davis, 1989, p. 320). As previously mentioned, organizations might miss out on streamlining daily work due to systems not being used, yet by anticipating users' reaction to a technology (Davis, 1989, p. 335) managers can therefore ease the implementation by introducing the usefulness of it. Users' acceptance to a system depends on how easy it is to use, what value it gives, and support from management.

2.3 Employee well-being

Employee well-being is a central concept in understanding how they function and feel in their daily work and becomes particularly important during periods of organizational changes such as digital transformation. Well-being is a central piece because it can have an effect on employees' ability to stay motivated, satisfied and productive while poor well-being can contribute to stress and resistance. Digital transformation intensifies these risks by introducing uncertainty, demands in new skills, and changes in work routines.

Han et al. (2025, p. 2) explains that a crucial part in employee well-being is in its organizational context, how well-being is perceived in the workplace. Employee well-being is explained as the employee's life quality, work satisfaction, as well as their emotional responses at work (Zheng et al., 2015, p. 624). When studying employee well-being, job satisfaction was seen as an indicator of performance and therefore also an important aspect to consider when examining employee well-being (Zheng et al., 2015, p. 624). An additional indicator of performance was linked to motivation (Putri et al., 2023, p. 26). Putri et al. (2023, p. 27) described motivation as an internal or external factor that encourages an individual to act or not and can thus be both positive and negative.

In an organizational context, well-being influences employee's ability to remain motivated, engaged, productive, and satisfied in their work. Poor employee well-being can, on the other hand, lead to stress, resistance to change, reduce motivation, and lower work performance. This becomes significant to study during digital transformation where technological complexity and uncertainty may affect employees with these factors (Valtonen & Holopainen, 2025, p. 44). Digital transformation therefore does not only represent a technological shift, but also a human and organizational challenge. The following sections will approach employee well-being through three main components: motivation, job satisfaction, and performance, and how these dimensions capture how employees experience and response to digital change. Additionally, all dimensions refer to the individual perspective. Specifically, digital transformation affects employees operationally within organizations and further how these aspects of affect are linked to technological implementation.

2.3.1 Employee Motivation

Employees require certain factors to gain motivation in order to be satisfied with their work and thus work efficiently. Hackman and Oldham (1976, p. 256) describe three phycological states to be achieved to attain internal motivation, leading to well work performance. The first is *experienced meaningfulness in work* meaning how employees perceive their work to fulfill a purpose and value to their life, secondly *experienced responsibility for outcome of work* by being given autonomy and the ability to make their own decisions (Hackman & Oldham, 1976, p. 256). Thirdly, *knowledge of the actual results of the work activities* defined as the employee receiving feedback and knows how well they are performing (Hackman & Oldham, 1976, p. 257). These three act as

underlying factors that motivate the employer to perform, therefore having job satisfaction. Along with the three phycological states, Bakker and Demerouti's (2007) theory highlights the importance of organizational support which is as significant.

To further understand how motivation is influenced, the Job Demands-Resources (JD-R) model is defined by categorizing the work environment into two categories, *job demands and job resources* (Bakker et al., 2001, p. 499). Job demands include the following aspects: physical, social, and organizational, which are associated with a psychological outcome, and since its impact, job demands therefore require a certain skillset to handle this (Bakker et al., 2001, p. 501). Job resources are working aspects that: a) help employees reach their goals, b) reduce job demand along with the psychological and physical costs that follow, c) encourage personal growth and motivation (Bakker et al., 2001, p. 501). Bakker et al. (2001, p. 501) divides these resources into two groups, organizational resources and social resources. Organizational resources regard autonomy, task variety, role clarity, and participation in decision-making, while social resources are the support one gets from peer groups, colleagues and family (Bakker et al., 2001, p. 501). Managerial support in the organization acts as a tool for employees to increase their capacity to finish tasks and can therefore generate better performance and job satisfaction (Nielsen et al., 2017, p. 105).

Further, the JD-R model consists of two psychological premises that are of importance when viewing the evolvement of motivation (Bakker & Demerouti, 2007, p. 313). The motivational process states that job resources have the potential to motivate in the form of engagement, decrease in skepticism, and great organizational performance (Bakker & Demerouti, 2007, p. 313). There is a positive correlation between motivation and performance which works as a tool to succeed with tasks and goals (Bakker & Demerouti, 2017, p. 275). Goel & Rashmi (2023, p. 539) also adds motivation as the primary reason to achieve goals and a main variable for individuals being committed to their work. Thus, job resources are a way to increase employee dedication to the specific task leading to the likelihood of work goals being achieved with triumph (Bakker & Demerouti, 2007, p. 314). Concluding that according to the JD-R model, work resources have the potential for motivational factors as well as contributing to high well-being (Nielsen et al., 2017, p. 105).

2.3.2 Employee motivation during digital transformation

In a digital transformation context, these motivational approaches become particularly important. Without having commitment of employees, digital transformation can become challenging and interfere with the desired outcome (Li & Jiang, 2025, p. 18). Li and Jiang (2025) support the research of Zhen and Ding (2024) which implies the importance of providing ability, motivation and opportunity for employees to inspire and retain motivation during a change, such as digital transformation. Ensuring a successful transformation can depend on three levels: individual, group, and organizational factors (Trenerry et al., 2021). Individual factors are determined by employee's technology acceptance, attitude, skills and training, and employee wellbeing which is directly linked with how the team communicates and collaborates (Trenerry et al., 2021, p. 14-15). These are further linked with management and organizational culture (Trenerry et al., 2021, p. 14-15) therefore highlighting the importance of providing suitable resources to maintain employee motivation during digital transformation.

However, employee motivation can go the other way and decrease during a digital transformation if the vision for the change is unclear. Webber et al. (2022, p. 233) state

that organizations that present an overly demanding digital transformation, employees may resist it if it becomes too difficult to achieve. Therefore, organizations that present digital transformation without a clear goal, understanding, or guidance, employees may feel overwhelmed and lead to reduced trust in leadership and increase resistance to change. Although employee motivation is a critical factor for employees to adapt to digital transformation, it is important to note that motivation alone is not enough to achieve that. Even if employees themselves are willing and motivated to learn, it is not the only factor to create actual behavioral change during a digital implementation (Zhou et al., 2025, p. 6). Employees need further support such as training, resources, and organizational support to be able to replace old work habits and adapt to the new digital way of working (Zhou et al., 2025, p. 7). Therefore, managers have the opportunity to adapt their leadership styles and act as motivation providers in this transition, as they encourage employers to experience and experiment in their learning process (Trenerry et al., 2021, p. 16) leading to acceptance of technology whilst keeping job satisfaction.

2.3.3 Employee Job-satisfaction

Job satisfaction emerges when a person evaluates their job as supportive to their own values, which creates a positive emotion that could lead to an increase in performance (Locke, 1969, p. 316). Meaning that when employees perceive their job to align with their own values and emotion, it creates a sense of satisfaction (Locke, 1969, p. 316). Another factor in increasing workers' job satisfaction is organizational support. Maan et al. (2020, p. 9) discusses how organizations who acknowledge their employees' contributions and support their well-being have a higher rate of people being satisfied with their job. In a business context, this highlights that not only does an employee build a positive emotion to their job by feeling fulfilled, but also the recognition and support received from their managers. Managers and organizations investing in supporting and showing up for their employees show a positive correlation with job satisfaction and performance, leading to less chance of workers leaving their job (Riggle et al., 2009, p. 1029). Not only does it lower chances of leaving, but employee job satisfaction is also important as it advocates towards employee commitment and engagement leading to achieving organizational and personal goals (Gross et al., 2021, p. 409-410).

2.3.4 Employee Job-satisfaction during digital transformation

With the adaption of digital technologies, it becomes crucial for an organization to learn and understand how and in what way digitalizing make an impact on employee's job satisfaction to better help form a successful implementation (Bolli & Pusterla, 2022, p. 264). Incorporating digital tools in the work entails changes in the job itself which may impact employees' level of satisfaction (Bolli & Pusterla, 2022, p. 264). Besides the nature of work changing, skills needed are required to be developed by the employees (Avtalion et al., 2025, p. 78993). The adaption of employees to the new digital systems is therefore critical to how managers can maintain job satisfaction amongst employees in a digital transformation. Pang and Lu (2018, p.39) add that employer's job satisfaction is often used in organizations as a measurable instrument to evaluate organizations' overall performance, thus an additional important factor for organizations to work on maintaining it.

A digital transformation is seen as successful when the work environment is one where managers support their employees by providing user-friendly tools and ongoing training (Avtalion et al., 2025, p. 78992). Once implementing digitalization in a smooth manner,

it can have multiple beneficial effects on job satisfaction. Work productivity can increase, operative work becomes more stimulating and interesting, employees feel a higher sense of autonomy which all results in increase of job satisfaction (Bolli & Pusteria, 2022, p. 288). On the other hand, the authors (2022, p. 288) raise the fact that fear of losing one's job to digitalization is still an issue that occurs with the implementation. However, managers' actions can alleviate this issue. Managers who use communication, transparency, and trust are more prone to motivate their team and engage the employees in the transformation process of digitalization (Ertiö et al., 2024, p. 402). By integrating the three skills in managers' leadership style, it can help them manage employees towards accepting, committing, and being prepared for the implementation (Ertiö et al., 2024, p. 407). Judge and Piccolo (2004, p. 759) argue that a manager can act as a leader that communicates vision, invites to an experimental environment and lead a successful change when having a leadership that works for inspiring and motivating employees. These leadership attributes are strongly correlated with higher employee satisfaction and motivation (Judge & Piccolo, 2004, p. 759-760).

Job satisfaction is important and a contributing factor for employee work related well-being, especially in the implementation of digital transformation. With the support of the organization and its managers, challenges can be addressed, and employee job satisfaction can be maintained to ensure the overall wellness of employees.

2.3.5 Employee Performance

Employee well-being has a high correlation with employee performance (Nielsen et al., 2017, p. 101). Performance is the behavior and action of people during work time and is further described as "*Performance is behavior with an evaluative component, behavior that can be evaluated as positive or negative for individual or organizational effectiveness*" (Motowildo et al., 1997, p. 72). Employee performance is the actual achievement of a worker of which the quality and quantity of the achievement is in line with the responsibilities given to the employee (Ismail & Muafi, 2019, p. 116). Motowildo et al. (1997) refer employee performance to which contributes to the overall organizational goals and according to Ismail and Muafi (2019, p. 117) it is of relevance to examine employee performance as it is a key factor for the company's performance. Additionally, employee performance acts as a competitive advantage and can promote organizational sustainability along with an increasement in productivity (Maryadi et al., 2026). The authors (2026, p. 10) highlight the modern changes that impact employee performance, changes such as digitalization, AI and technology, and remote work, etc. which are required to increase flexibility as well as change how performance is measured.

Another important perspective is how organizational resources encourage and maintain employee performance. Job resources in the JD-R model explains two main components that are organizational- and social recourses whereas these act as great motivation that leads to strong engagement and high employee performance (Bakker & Demerouti, 2007, p. 313). Support, autonomy and feedback are a few of the resources needed to ensure increased motivation thus profund employee performance (Bakker & Demerouti, 2007, p. 314). Ogueyungbo et al. (2020, p. 9 and 12) highlights the importance of support from a managerial role to advocate employee engagement and proves that an environment which reinforces this kind of support improves the chances of having well performed employees.

Hackman and Oldham (1976, p. 256-257) discuss further the three psychological states that individuals need: experienced meaningfulness of the work, experienced responsibility for outcome of work, and knowledge of the actual results of the work activities. If these psychological states are believed to be achieved, it gives the individual an internal motivation and positive affect leading to continued performance in the future (Hackman & Oldham, 1976, p. 256). In addition, it is important to take individual differences into account, which can alter employee growth and strength, which explains how strongly an individual wants to grow and develop (Hackman & Oldham, 1976, p. 258). Individuals with higher need for personal development will answer better to a work environment with high motivation (Hackman & Oldham, 1976, p. 258).

2.3.6 Employee performance during Digital Transformation

It is of relevance to understand how employee performance is affected during digital transformation, as it can act as a tool for managers to adapt behavior towards implementation of new technologies. The performance of an employee when organizations undergo digital transformation has a positive effect as it improves individuals' skills, enhances both motivation and autonomy which leads to easier adaption (Zhou et al., 2025, p. 6). Although, the relationship between technology and performance is not purely positive. The authors (2025, p. 6) point out the importance of the unlearning process, meaning employees must first let go of old habits and routines to fully accept new adaptions. Managers can further help the organization commit to digital transformation through offering learning possibilities, communication, and knowledge sharing for enhancement of employee performance (Zhou et al., 2025, p. 8).

Researchers Karr-Wisniewski and Lu (2010, p. 1068) add to the findings that technology increase employee performance and enhances productivity, however only to a certain point. At first, digitalization and technological tools have a great contribution to productivity as employers become more efficient and dispute their time accordingly, on the other hand too many technologies have the opposite effect (Karr-Wisniewski & Lu, 2010, p. 1068). Technology overload is described as too much information and systems distracting and overwhelming to employees, especially for those who rely heavily on the systems (Karr-Wisniewski & Lu, 2010, p. 1068). This concept is closely related to “technostress” that is the overload and uncertainty employees feel regarding technologies thus leading to reduction in productivity, motivation loss, and a negative impact on employee performance (Tarafdar et al., 2007, p. 303 and 322). In later studies (Valta et al., 2024) it has been added that employee's digital mindset plays a significant role in the level of technostress an individual feels.

Given these challenges, it becomes particularly important to analyze how employees can be supported in accepting modern changes of digitalization in the context of digital transformation. Hanelt et al. (2021, p. 1173) research predicts recourses that are needed to allow engaged employees to accept digital transformation in an organization. It is pointed out that the design of how organizations operate is compelled to be developed to acquire technological skills and capabilities amongst employees (Hanelt et al., 2021, p. 1173). Furthermore, the authors (2021, p. 1175-1176) discussed that employees need constant learning of the technologies used to allow working with them, and along with organizational support, they act as some of the key resources needed to structure a digital transformation. Zhen and Ding (2024) add that organizations should focus on empowering employees' ability, motivation, and opportunity to engage them in digital transformation. Ability empowerment is about their IT skills and how important it is with

proper training, whilst motivation empowerment regards how information is supplied to motivate usage of digital systems, and lastly, opportunity empowerment to enable employees to use the technologies and enhance their work (Zhen & Ding, 2024, p. 10-11). In conclusion, organizations and managers focusing on building technical skills, training and support can enhance engagement in employee's adaption to digital transformation and thus their performance (Zhen & Ding, 2024: Hanelt et al., 2021).

Overall, findings suggest that the outcome of employee performance during digital transformation depends on an interplay between technological opportunities and managerial maintenance. Digitalization is proven to enhance efficiency, productivity, and performance while the success of it depends on organizations' ability to balance the digital implementation with employee well-being.

2.4 Conceptual framework

To get an understanding of how the theoretical framework is integrated with the research purpose, the following conceptual framework is illustrated. This framework connects theoretical perspectives from digital transformation, decision-making, well-being, managerial support, and employee technology acceptance to provide an extensive picture of how these elements interact (see Figure 1).

The dependent variable of the conceptual framework is *Employee Well-being,* including motivation, satisfaction, and performance. These dimensions are central to the study because they reflect the main organizational outcome of how digital transformation, managerial decision-making, managerial support, and employee technology acceptance interact. The other dimensions in the framework influence how employees experience digital transformation, making *employees well-being* the key barometer to if digital transformation is successful. Every other aspect of the framework is influenced by the effects of employee well-being and is the central outcome in which organizations need to consider.

Above *Employee Well-being* is *Managerial Decision-making* and *Digital transformation* positioned (see Figure 1). *Managerial Digital transformation* represents organizational changes that drive from digital technology and the changes that bring in the work process. *Managerial Decision-making* regards how the decisions in digital transformation are made and how satisfactory they are. The arrow from digital transformation shows that digitalization changes the demands in decision-making. In turn, decision-making sets the frame for how well-grounded the support managers can give leading to *Managerial support. Managerial support* concerns how managers assist their employees with everything from encouragement, training to resources. If the employees perceive they get the support they need from their managers it conditions the feeling of motivation, satisfaction and performance leading to *Employee well-being.* Additionally, *managerial support* can lead to higher *employee technological acceptance*, which further motivates employees to use the systems leading to satisfaction in the workplace and performance.

Further, *Employee well-being* goes back to *Managerial Decision-making* and *Digital transformation* since it can affect what decisions are being made since the quality of the decision relies on the impact it has on the employees. Additionally, *Managerial support* continues to *Employee technology acceptance* since how new digital work processes are implemented and received is dependent on the support that comes from management. If employees perceive digital technologies as useful and manageable, the likelihood of technology acceptance increases.

Employee technology acceptance in turn affects if the digital transformation was perceived successfully. The whole concept acts as a loop process in which digital transformation influences managerial decision-making that shapes managerial support, which influences technology acceptance, that lastly contributes to employee well-being, which determines the success of digital transformation. Since all dimensions of the framework are interconnected (see Figure 1), inadequacies in one aspect may create chain effects that influence the functioning of the entire process. Good and efficient managerial support for digital transformation can lead to enhanced employee well-being and more effective decision-making in future revised digital transformation processes.

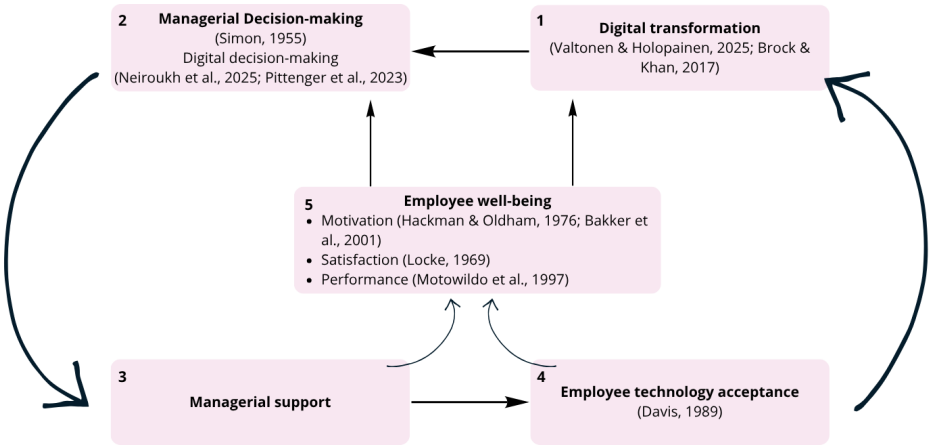


Figure 1. Conceptual framework

3. Methodology

This chapter explains the methodological foundation of the study and how the research was designed, conducted, and analyzed. It outlines the philosophical foundation guiding the study, the research approach and design, as well as methods for collecting and analyzing empirical data. Participants' selection, interview guide, and processed data are included. Finally, the chapter addresses research quality and ethical considerations.

3.1 Research philosophy

Research philosophy composes the world view the research is conducted from and explains the system of belief and assumptions of the development of knowledge (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 131). Thus, showcasing how we will review and conduct our data. In business and management research fields, five different research philosophies are introduced: positivism, interpretivism, critical realism, postmodernism, and pragmatism (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 145). Positivism is based on natural sciences, and its objective is to generalize, which means that the researcher taken on an objective role tries to produce measurable and observable results rather than own perceptions (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 146). Interpretivism believes that the individual is separate from the actual phenomena; humans all have different cultures and circumstances that affect social reality. Compared to positivism that wants to be able to generalize, interpretivism wishes to create a profaned understanding of a specific context and takes on a more subjective approach (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 150). Critical realism focuses on explaining what is seen and experience by looking for the structures that form these events (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 148-149). Postmodernism looks at the importance of language and power relations when viewing reality. The postmodernist philosophy questions truth and tries to bring forth perspectives that have been obscured (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 152). Lastly, pragmatism means when frameworks support action is the only time, they are purposeful. Research is done to give clear solutions for the future (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 153).

For this research, we will adapt an interpretivism philosophy to understand our results and data gathering. Since we will be conducting a qualitive study with the purpose of understanding managers and employees' subjective experiences, the interpretivism approach is deemed the most suitable. The choice to do a qualitative study is due to the gap in previous research literature. Li (2020, p. 815) highlights that there is a significant research gap as limited previous research has been conducted through a qualitative study. The purpose is therefore to practically understand how individuals interpret and experience digital transformation. The research aims to get an overview of how managers view their decision-making and how employee experience motivation, job satisfaction and performance. These are not objectives of phenomena but rather subjective and dependent on the context. Therefore, is the interpretivist approach suitable when answering our research question.

3.1.1 Ontology

The ontological assumption refers to what reality is and its existence (Collis & Hussey, 2014, p. 47). Collis & Hussey (2014, p. 47) discusses two different views, interpretivism and positivism. Positivism believes there to be one reality which everyone perceives the same and that therefore reality is objective, independent of the researcher. Interpretivism views social reality subjectively as the assumption is that individual has their own

conception, making multiple realities suitable for each individual (Collis & Hussey, 2014, p. 47).

Since we have an interpretivism view in our ontological assumption. Our purpose is to study the managerial balance between digital transformation in decision-making and employee well-being. Which means that there might not be one general truth about digitalization; managers and employees can perceive the same situation differently. Thus, it requires us to get an insight into both managers and employees' understanding of their personal experiences.

3.1.2 Epistemology

The epistemological assumption concerns the view of what is considered legitimate knowledge and how to gain that knowledge (Collis & Hussey, 2014, p. 47). The positivistic views believe that only quantifiable variables that are observable can be viewed as legitimate knowledge. The idea is to be objective and neutral (Collis & Hussey, 2014, p. 47). Interpretivism on the contrary tries to get closer to what is researched and believes that knowledge is created through interpretation and the understanding of individuals' subjective experiences (Collis & Hussey, 2014, p. 47). Since the interpretivism approach is connected to the social construct, the approach correlates with qualitative studies such as conducting interviews (Collis & Hussey, 2014, p. 46).

With the interpretivist approaches our expectation is to get a deeper understanding of what the individual's perception of what reality is, their knowledge and thoughts. The research method will develop further on the participants' subjective views such as the manager's perception of their decision-making in correlation with digitalization and thus how they believe this affects employee well-being. Beyond the subjective understanding of the managers' perception of employee well-being, we also aim to complete this by adding the employees' understanding of this well-being, looking at job satisfaction, motivation, and job performance. This correlates with the idea that knowledge is created through interaction and not through objective measurements.

3.1.3 Axiology

The axiological assumption looks at the effect values and ethics have on the research (Saunders et al., 2019, p. 134). The researcher needs to take a stand in how or if they want their own perceptions of values to have a role in the research (Saunders et al., 2019, p. 134). According to Saunders et al. (2019, p. 134), our choices reflect our values and beliefs. If a researcher prefers the method of interviews, he or she might hold this date of higher value compared to questioners (Saunders et al., 2019, p. 134). Interpretivists believe the researcher possesses values and is an integrated part of their research (Collis & Hussey, 2014, p. 48).

Furthermore, since the chosen research philosophical is interpretivism, we believe that our values have had an impact on the research. For example, when we were generating ideas, we looked at what we considered important and of value. The role of well-being for employees in a highly digitalized world derives from our beliefs about how the development of technology will play out and its effect on humanity. In this research, values and ethical beliefs will mirror both the participants and the researcher. We believe that the perspective that concerns employee well-being and how to have a sustainable organization is important and therefore something we have actively chosen to study. In interpretivism, the researcher is a part of what is researched (Collis & Hussey, 2014, p.

48). Meaning that the researcher interprets the interviews and chooses what is deemed important in exchange with the participants. An important aspect of this is that this affects our research therefore we need to be mindful about our own assumptions.

3.2 Research approach and design

The methodological choices made in a study form the foundation of how the study is structured and how the research question is addressed. By outlining the chosen approach and design this section establish the coherence of the study and demonstrates how to proceed with answering the research question. The following subsections therefore presents the chosen research approach, motivate the qualitative design, and describe the process which relevant literature was identified.

3.2.1 Research approach

For the research to be performed, there is a need to clarify what research approach has been chosen. There are three reasons for understanding why the research approach is of importance (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 159). Firstly, one can make a more well-grounded decision with the research design (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 159). Secondly, it helps pick the right strategies and methods that work for our study (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 159). Lastly, it can help with adapting the research after different limitations such as insufficient knowledge or data (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 159). To answer a research question, the theory that is used and how it's used is of high relevance and is furthermore explained by deductive, inductive, or abductive (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 155).

Deduction is the most common approach for theory development and has its roots in natural science where the reasoning lies with if all premises are true the conclusion must also be true (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 154 & 156). The process in deduction is that the researcher bases its question in existing theory, by looking at already stated theory the research field is there as developed (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 156). On the other hand, induction starts with data gathering to then later formulate the theory. Inductive research puts its origin in the individual observation to then later conclude general patterns (Collis & Hussey, 2014, p. 7). Abduction could refer to an intermediate position between induction and deduction. Abduction alternates between data and theory. The researcher goes back and forth to compare and develop the research as they go (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 158-159).

For this research, an abductive research approach will be taken. Compared to induction where a hypothesis is created first to then developing the theory (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 154-155). Abductive approach moves between both theory and data. When developing this research, we created a theoretical base with frameworks such as: TAM, decision-making theory, and JD-R. After the theoretical base was established came the data collection in the format of interviews which will then be analyzed in the context of the theory to build on our understanding further. Whereas a theoretical framework has been established, the inductive approach was not deemed suitable. Additionally, the main objective with the conducted research is to get insight and understanding of the phenomena and therefore not try to prove a hypothesis further concluding that a deductive approach would not be fitting.

3.2.2 Research design

The research design refers to how the research question will be answered and how it will be conducted (Saunders et al., 2019, p. 173). Saunders et al. (2019, p. 174) introduces quantitative, qualitative, and mixed methods as three common research designs in the methodological choice.

Quantitative research design is correlated with collecting data that can be translated to a generalized outcome (Sanders et al., 2019, p. 178). This approach looks at the link between different variables where the resulting data is derived numerically and analyses this data with the help of statistics and graphs (Sanders et al., 2019, p. 178). Data collection in a quantitative research design tends to be questioners or structed interviews (Sanders et al., 2019, p. 178). Qualitative research design, on the other hand, is associated with the socially subjective reality and aims to understand the underlying meaning though wording and images and connects to the interpretive philosophy (Sanders et al., 2019, p. 179-180). The method for data collection is usually unstructured or semi-structured interviews (Sanders et al., 2019, p. 180). Lastly, mixed method research designs combine both the quantitative and the qualitative approach where the researcher gathers data from both approaches to cover a more extensive overview of the issue (Sanders et al., 2019, p. 185).

Since this study is based on an interpretive philosophy with an abductive approach, the chosen research design suited would be a qualitive research design. When developing an already established theory, qualitative study is deemed most fitting (Zheng et al., 2015, p. 624). Further correlating well with both interpretivism and an abductive approach. The method that will be used is a semi-structured interview with the purpose of approaching our participants to understand their subjective meaning rather than standardize the results to ensure validity. According to Collis & Hussey (2014, p. 133-134), semi-structured interviews mean that the researcher prepares some questions as a baseline but is adaptable with suitable follow up questions throughout. Semi-structured interviews are well suited when the purpose is to be able to analyze the answers of the participant's own worldview (Collis & Hussey, 2014, p. 134). Allowing us to be flexible and open to continuing building on topics or comments made by the participants. Our research question: *During digital transformation, how does managers' decision-making affect employee motivation, job satisfaction, and performance?* Refers to managers' personal views on their understanding of balancing the digital transition in decision-making and the employee's well-being. The purpose of conducting interviews is to get the employees perception to add to the manager's view.

3.2.3 Literature search and Review

When choosing a topic for research, the next essential step is to do a literature research which is a systematic process that explores the already existing knowledge on a certain topic (Collis & Hussey, 2014, p. 76). In other words, one conducts a literature review to evaluate the proposed theory which showcases what literature has been used and how it is of relevance for the research being conducted (Collins & Hussey, 2014, p. 87). Once a literature search had been made by the authors, it helped gather an understanding of digital transformation in organizations and what changes it required. Additionally, the literature search assisted in expanding the knowledge regarding employees' well-being and how it correlated with the future of digitalization. Further, through orchestrating a literature research, the authors of the thesis identified what existing literature had been made in important areas, how it functions in theory and the purposed research gap. The process of the research revealed limited research being made on digital transformation

effects on managers' decision making and its influence on employee motivation, job satisfaction, and employee performance. Researchers like Guan et al. (2022), Yang et al. (2024) and Stamante et al. (2021) all referred to the need of this gap to be studied in future research.

However, Saunders et al. (2023, p. 74) showcases the relevance of being critical of the literature research one conducts for the thesis. From the literature review, a clear argument should be able to be drawn about what has been found in previous research and what is not known (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 75). The authors (2023, p. 76) further describe being critical is to question, evaluate, and form an own judgment of the literature whilst analyzing and justifying conclusions in writing, not only describing. We made sure this was done through viewing multiple different literature before forming an argument and be sure to cite correctly. Furthermore, more than one literature and theory were analyzed and compared, to spot strengths, weaknesses, and make informed judgements. At the beginning of the search, the university's database EBSCO was frequently used which through the following research was used to gain a broader a deeper understanding on the subject, Rivero (2025), Yang et al. (2024), Zhang and Jin (2023), Stamate et al (2021), SimanTov-Nachlieli (2024) and Qiao (2024). Through this peer-reviewed research, it was possible to gather necessary key concepts, background, and existing discussions on the topic. Later, through the literature mentioned, the reference list was researched for further sources to increase the knowledge gap amongst the authors of this thesis. Access given through the library of the university enabled access to scientific journals, books, and articles which strengthened reliability and credibility.

Once having access, using key words and search terms differently depending on what aspects of the study were covered. Through the university library, databases like EBSCO, and journals, search terms such as “digital transformation”, “digital implementation”, and “technology implementation” were used. This was done to form the foundation for the theory section which was digital transformation implementation and what can be the underlying causes for a successful or failed implementation. Further, “employee well-being", “employee motivation”, “employee job-satisfaction", and “employee performance” were search terms used to examine how employee well-being was viewed in an organizational context. To examine the correlation, relationship, and compare between digital transformation and employee well-being, Boolean operators such as “AND” and “OR” were applied. Additionally, to examine how decision making has changed when organizations transform to digitalization search terms such as “decision making during digitalization”, “data-driven decision making”, and “AI in decision making”.

The research approach for this thesis is abductive; hence it is based on both developing a conceptual framework from gathering different theories and having a clear goal with a research question to fill a research gap then developing a new theory (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 78). Firstly, through critical literature search, a research gap was identified, thus creating an aim for this thesis later. Also, through a critical literature search, theories were gathered, and a development of a conceptual framework was done. This was done by using secondary literature which is defined as formally published journals and books (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 83) who are official and peer-reviewed sources, that are highly cited. The sources were checked for key words and terms who are of relevance to this thesis research topic. Grey or primary literature refers to sources that are not published by commercial publishers and could be government reports, etc. (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 83) and two of those were used. One of which was SCB (2026) a Swedish state agency to present statical numbers and WHO (2026) the World Health Organization to define

concept of well-being. To further ensure accuracy and credibility, original sources were combined with more recent studies e.g. Davis (1989) and Valtonen and Holopainen (2025) or Simon (1955) and Mason and Nightingale (2026). While including original concepts with newer ones certify key theories with recent studies to demonstrate relevance and ever evolving topic.

With the wide range of access to multiple sources on the university's library, both physical and digital ones, and different journals such as *Journal of Management*, *Journal of Management Studies, Academy of Management Review, and Journal of Applied Psychology* it enabled a small limitation due to existing research and theories being of relevance. However, a more noteworthy limitation has been the research gap in how employee's well-being is being affected by digital transformation and managers' decision making in such implementations. Due to this fact, it has been difficult to develop a connection between employee well-being, digital transformation, and managerial decision making. Nevertheless, it was this gap that allowed an opportunity to contribute with insights to the field and allow for future research.

3.3 Data collection

The data collection chapter outlines the procedure used to gather empirical materials aligned with the research design, to properly answer the research question. Conducting data in this research will be done through semi-structured interviews with open questions, to enable different and honest perspectives from respondents. This method for data collecting is suitable for qualitative and interpretivist research to investigate the perception of managers and employees in an organizational context. In the following sections, a thorough analysis will be presented on sample selection, the theoretical consideration underlying the interview design, and the process of conducting the interviews.

3.3.1 Sample selection

Conducting qualitative data can be done through printed material such as text, diagrams, and other images, or audio and visual material such as recordings of interviews etc. (Collis & Hussey, 2014, p. 130). To further collect the data through an interpretivist perspective, Collis and Hussey (2014, p. 131) present an overview of the data collection process. All the people who are considered for statical purposes are called a population, from that you draw a sample selection from the wider population which is the first step in data collecting (Collis & Hussey, 2014, p. 131). Often, it is close to impossible to select and analyze all potential data due to time and access restriction, which is why selecting a sample is the way to proceed (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 292). Further, since the data is under interpretivist scope, it needs no statistical analyzation to generalize the sample to the population thus, a non-random sample is acceptable (Collis & Hussey, 2014, p. 131). For the purpose of this study, the sample is large sized Business economics organizations operating in Sweden, who have or are in the process of implementing digital transformation. Furthermore, a collection of nine participant was selected and interviewed. According to Elmholdt et al. (2026, p. 4) to reach data saturation in qualitative research a number between 6-12 interviews are deemed suitable. Thus, nine participant was believed to be enough to capture the overall view of the participants experiences and perceptions.

An important factor to weigh in when sample selecting is how it relates to the research question along with the research purpose, which was in mind when conducting the data. For this thesis, it was significant to choose a sample method where the respondents have some requirements that relate to their ability to contribute data to the research question.

To conduct the relevant findings in which answers this thesis research question, managers who make decisions, operative och strategic ones, were recruited. This is to expand our understanding of how managers' decision-making processes are made in digital transformation and further comprehend its effect on employee work related well-being. In addition, to create a broader understanding, it was essential to conduct interviews from an employee's perspective, how they perceive digitalization's effect on their motivation, job satisfaction, and performance. Moreover, two candidates were recruited who contain valuable knowledge and experience within the field, who were included as specialists within digitalization and technology to further strengthen the study. One of the two has been working with technology and working as a consultant in adapting digitalization, while the second has been working during digital transformation in their company and won a prize for the success of it. Adding them to the sample increases the overall relevance and depth of findings.

With this specific requirement, the authors of this thesis selected participants who specifically can provide relevant, in-depth insights which are described as judgmental or purposive sampling (Collis & Hussey, 2014, p. 132). Using this method to assemble data relies heavily on an individual's own judgment to select those who can best answer the research question which was furthermore done through existing contacts such as LinkedIn connections (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 321 & 245). With this in mind, a further requirement was to conduct interviews with one manager and one or two employees from the same firm. This was to increase validity and receive more than one perception of how the digital implementation was going through the lenses of both managers and employees. However, due to time restrictions and no response, this requirement was not fully met. As seen in Table 1, the company *Kivik* was the only one to not meet this requirement as no feedback was received from contacting five different managers. However, we choose to continue to add the employees' perspective to the data since it was impactful on the findings.

Furthermore, the authors chose to select a snowball sampling or networking to expand the sample. Through asking the first respondent if they can recommend anyone else who has the same relevance for the study (Collis & Hussey, 2014, p. 132). Once making contact with one or two respondents, one can ask to identify other who additionally recommend another and so on (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 323). Making the first contact is where one struggles most, but once it is done the sample grows like a snowball being rolled in snow (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 323). In this thesis, it was of high relevance as the aim was to collect data from two or three respondents from each company. However, its effectiveness varied as can be seen from the case of *Kivik*, in which the employees was not able to provide a manager for an interview. Overall, the selected sampling strategy assured relevant perspectives thereby supporting the study's aim of generating meaningful data.

Table 1. Overview of participants

Role	*Company*	*Background*	*Length of interview*	*Date of interview*
Employee 1- Gran	Simrishamn	1 year experience in consulting business	52 min	20/3-26
Manager 1 - Tall	Simrishamn	1 year experience as manager in consulting business, 8+ years in the company	51 min	23/3-26
Employee 1 - Björk	Kivik	1 year experience in consulting business	51 min	25/3-26
Specialist	Lyckeby	10+ years experience in the field	45 min	30/3-26
Specialist	Trelleborg	4+ years experience in the company	58 min	31/3-26
Manager 1 - Ek	Ystad	1 year experience as a manager in consulting business, 4+ in the company	38 min	31/3-26
Employee 2 - Bok	Kivik	4 years experience in consulting business	53 min	02/4-26
Employee 2 - Rönn	Simrishamn	1 year experience in the consulting business	46 min	07/4-26
Employee 1 – Lind	Ystad	1 year experience in the consulting business	40 min	24/4-26

The following will be a short description of each organization and participant.

Simrishamn is a global service company that provides services in strategy, consulting, technology, digital transformation, and operations. Participants are *Tall, Gran, and Rönn.*

Ystad is a global service company that provides audit, tax, and advisory services. Participants are *EK,* and *Lind*

Kivik is also a global service company offering services in audit, tax, consulting, and advisory supporting clients both in the private and public sector. The participants are *Björk,* and *Bok*.

Trelleborg is a chef product manager in HR operating in one of Nordics' biggest postal and logistics companies, that have recently implemented a successful digital transformation which has resulted in prizes for their work. Participant, *Trelleborg.*

Lyckeby is a consulting manager who specializes in AI with a background in technology, AI, and management. Participant, *Lyckeby*.

3.3.2 Interview guide

The interview guide acts as a skeleton for the structure of the semi-structured interviews (Bell et al., 2019, p. 436). Semi-structured interviews give the interviewer a base, while still having the possibility to discuss further follow-up questions (Bell et al., 2019, p.

436). Giving the interviewer freedom and flexibility to base coming questions on the interviewee's responses (Bell et al., 2019, p. 436). When formulating the questions for the interview guide, open-ended questions were created. Open-ended questions, compared to closed questions, do not lead the participant towards a specific answer but rather provide them with the possibility to answer in their own way (Bell et al., 2019, p. 273; Collis & Hussey, 2014, p. 212). Additionally, academic terms that the participant may not be familiar with avoided misconception and smoothing the flow of the interview (Bell et al., 2019, p. 440).

When designing the interview guide, we chose to create two versions; one for the employees and one for the managers (see Appendix). This was executed to ensure that the interview matched our participants and could be derived back to the research question. Both guides were divided into main themes, *Technology, decision-making, job performance, job satisfaction* and, *motivation.* The area of *technology* was gathered to get a baseline in the participants' usage of digital tools in their work to later develop into the integration of the system and how they are perceived. *Decision-making* explored employees' effect on their managers' decisions while the interview guide for managers directed its focus on how digital tools were involved in the decision-making process. *Job performance* conducted questions to the perceived individual results in relation to digital transformation, while *job satisfaction* and *motivation* regarded the participants feeling towards their work (see Appendix). Thus, making sure all responses are correlated with the chosen theory, making sure of its relevance for the research question. Further, the interview guide was originally created in Swedish and then translated to English since the organizations interviewed are Swedish and was therefore substantial to ensure the flow of the questions in the participants native language. See both versions in Appendix.

To make sure we had a working interview guide a pilot study was also conducted on a manager. The pilot study was a valuable way to ensure the questions worked as they were intended and trying our skills in relation to interviewing. Overall, the pilot study went smoothly, the participant understood the questions and responded in depth. Further we got some potential insights in how to improve the final guide. This regarded clarifying some of the questions that were unclear and also cutting down a few of the questions that were overlapping since we noticed the time going over our initial expectance.

3.3.3 Conducting the interview

All participants were reached out to via email or on the application LinkedIn with a short presentation of us and a description of the purpose of the study, which was as followed; how managers balance digital transformation with employee well-being, with a focus on the use of digital tools in decision-making. Additionally, a consent form was attached to clarify usage of confidential information and GDPR for the participants to take part before the interview was conducted. The animosity of both the participants and the organization and a verbal conformation for accepting the interview to be recorded was highlighted further in the introduction of the interview before recording. The majority of the interviews were held via Microsoft Teams, except for one that was held physically. This was due to geographical reasons, except for the one conducted on site. This interview was able to be done in person, for the sake of being able to observe non-verbal cues.

The interviews were conducted in Swedish since this was the native language of the participants to guarantee familiarity and security to elaborate on own reflections and opinions. During the interviews, the participants were given freedom of reflection without restriction with the interviewer adjusting the follow-up questions from the answers that

were given. Some follow-up questions were thought out in advance while others were thought out in the moment. Thus, creating an environment that motivated the participants to share their experiences, thoughts, and ideas. Totally, nine interviews were conducted and lasted between 38-58 minutes with an average of 48 minutes. In the end of each interview the participant had the opportunity to develop their answers or if they wanted to add something additionally that seemed of relevance that we might had missed.

3.4 Data analysis

The analysis of the empirical material was conducted using a thematic analysis following the six-phase framework proposed by Braun & Clarke (2006). This approach was chosen because it enables a systematic overview of found patterns and aligns with the study's interpretivists orientation and abductive research approach. The purpose was to identify recurring experiences and perceptions related to digital decision-making and its implications for employee well-being.

Thematic analysis and Data structure

When conducting a qualitative method, thematic analysis is commonly used when analyzing data (Braun & Clarke, 2006, p. 77). Braun & Clarke (2006, p. 79) describes thematic analysis as a method of identifying and categorizing different themes that are visual in the collected data. Given the nature of the study, understanding employees and managers experiences regarding digital decision-making and its effect on well-being, as well as the study's interpretivist research philosophy and its abductive research approach, a thematic analysis was deemed suitable since it enables getting each individual response. Thematic analysis is beneficial because of its flexibility and usability (Braun & Clarke, 2006). It utilizes the possibility of moving between both theory and empiric findings (Braun & Clarke, 2006, p. 86), which is in line with the chosen abductive research approach. Braun & Clarke (2006, p. 97) adds that thematic analysis is considered a relevant easy analysis to learn and use when having little prior knowledge of methodology in qualitative studies while still managing to gather large amount of data into relevant key concepts.

Therefore, this study has followed Braun & Clarke's (2006) six phases of thematic analysis; (1) familiarize oneself with the conducted data, (2) produce codes that seems relevant, (3) explore themes, (4) refine chosen themes, (5) chose the specific themes, (6) conduct the report. Firstly, the *familiarization phase* regarded reading the transcripts on its whole to create an overview and an understanding of the data. In this study, the recorded interviews were transcribed and read by each one of the authors multiple times and later together. Notes and observations were written down to get an understanding of the recurring patterns, enabling to get an initial overview of the participants experiences. Thereafter, the *producing codes phase* of the material began by highlighting all relevant aspects, ending with 55 unique initial codes. These codes were generated from the participants descriptions and wording. These codes were further clustered into *integrated codes* (see Figure 2), being the overall generic responses from the participants. *Exploring themes phase* were conducted through gathering and identifying the initial codes into possible themes based on conceptual similarity and recurring patterns in the participants responses. Thus, allowing a greater identification of the relationship between individual experiences and broader concepts.

Further, the themes were reviewed and evaluated an additional time in the *reefing themes phase* to make sure the chosen themes created a justifiable picture of the data material. The authors went back to the transcripts to make sure each theme accurately reflected the participant perceptions and that each theme were clearly distinctive. Lastly, "organizational support", "time optimization"," implementation strategy", and "usability" were chosen in the *specifying themes phase.*

The integrated codes that were identified from the transcriptions were based on participants' citations, related "*Motivation", "Time management", "Education, experts and encouragement", "Acceptance or Resistance"," Balance between human and technology", and "Quality of results"*. From these codes, we then identified candidate themes: *"Communication & Transparency" and "organizational culture", "Efficiency and quality" and "Automate repetitive tasks"," Learning environment" and "Managerial influence"," Strategic system utilization" and "Usage behavior"*. From these themes, it was possible to deprive the final themes that were*" Organizational support", "Time optimization", "Implementation strategy", and "Usability"* (see Figure 2).

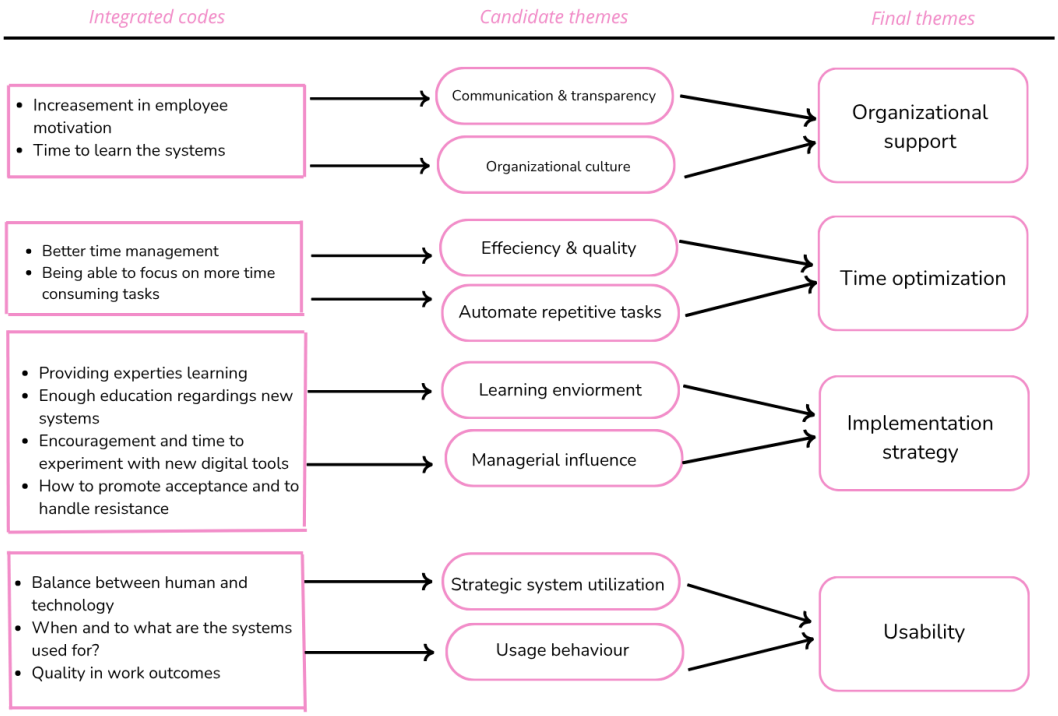


Figure 2. Data structure

3.5 Research quality

To determine if the presented findings and conclusions can be trusted and withhold criticism, the research quality needs to be evaluated (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 213). When discussing quantitative studies, reliability and validity play crucial parts for assessments. However, Lincoln & Guba (1985) built this with an alternative way of evaluating research quality that is more in line with interpretivists' studies. Additionally, the authors (1985) suggest trustworthiness as the main criteria for a qualitative study. Lincoln & Guba (1985, p. 300) further divides trustworthiness into four criteria: credibility, transferability,

dependability, and confirmability. Due to the study's research philosophy and research design the research quality will be looked at from Lincoln & Guba´s (1985) trustworthiness.

In qualitative studies one observes the socially constructed reality, and the believed experience can be perceived in multiple ways (Bell et al., 2019, p. 363). Credibility therefore explains how credible and convincing the results are (Bell et al., 2019, p. 363). Described as the most important technique to attain credibility is member checks (Lincoln & Guba, 1985, p. 314). Member checks give the participants an opportunity to participate and confirm statements (Lincoln & Guba, 1985, p. 314). In the conducted interviews follow-up questions such as “Do I understand you correctly if...?” were asked to validate the participant experience and ensure the right picture was painted. Additional follow-up questions were also created as the interview went along to continue the participants' specific answers. In the end of all interviews the participant was able to add if they felt that something of importance was missing or forgotten, highlighting credibility in the study.

Transferability explains how the results could be relevant in other studies, trying to see similarities between situations (Drisko, 2025, p. 103). Lincoln & Guba (1985, p. 316) argue that in qualitative studies transferability is almost impossible since the objective is to get the individuals own version of the experience and therefore not possible to transfer. Instead, the researcher should provide a thick description of the context enabling the reader to make their own opinion if the results seem suitable in other contexts (Lincoln & Guba, 1985, p. 316). Thus, a thorough explanation of the study and its applicable organizations and the chosen participants have been made. Leading the criteria of transferability over to the reader.

Dependability is the research's relevance and trustworthiness over time (Lincoln & Guba, 1985, p. 316-317). In qualitative research, experience and meaning can differ, making it an ever-moving phenomena (Lim, 2025, p. 222-223). Dependability showcases despite this that consistency is of importance to verify the study's dependability (Lim, 2025, p. 223). To ensure dependability is attained, an inquiry auditor can examine both the process and results of the study (Lincoln & Guba, 1985, p. 317-318). This research has a clear and detailed description of its process, with explained research philosophy to highlight the study's baseline, how the data collection has been conducted with sample selection, and how the interviews were formulated. The results in the form of findings and discussion are derived from the data and are highly visible. Because of the research thorough process, it demonstrates the study's dependability.

Research is difficult to keep entirely objective but shall strive for objectiveness as far as possible for the research to be deemed confirmable (Bell et al., 2019, p. 365). Confirmability explains that the results should be built on data and facts without letting the researcher's personal beliefs get in the way (Bell et al., 2019, p. 365). Highlighting the study's naturalness, all findings have been connected to the participants' citations and their own examples. Further, the authors have continuously reflected their potential effect on the study in the form of previous experience and personal values. The authors had limited prior knowledge of the field of digital transformation and decision-making contributing to a bigger neutrality than if prior knowledge was acquired, thus leading to something to compare with. Halpern (1983, cited in Lincoln & Guba, 1985, p. 320) brings up researchers' intentions and starting point with the study as a state for bias and something to consider with confirmability. There could be an argument for the authors' preconceived notion that digital transformation would have a negative impact on

employee well-being since this was the reason for developing this field. Therefore, the criterion of confirmability is hard to determine, but the study still tried to take measures to enhance it by grounding findings in participants' responses and maintaining reflexibility throughout the process.

3.6 Criticism and Ethical implications

Ethical concerns arise often when research involves human participants (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 232) and is further described as *"the standards of behavior that guide your conduct in relation to the rights of those who become the subject of your work or are affected by it"*. (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 252-253). Meaning, certain rules and principles should guide how one acts and to make sure their rights are being respected. As this research relied on personal and sensitive information about individuals as employers and managers, and organizations in big, it was highly important to keep all the participants' anonyms and their organizations. Saunders et al. (2023, p. 259) states that it is significant to estimate and evaluate potential risks to avoid harming people involved in the research. By analyzing what risks there is and what potentially could go wrong, one can beforehand work towards avoiding them risks (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 259).

Because the data in this research can be sensitive to both the individual and to the organization due to confidentially and secured information, it was important to follow the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) that is a comprehensive privacy and security law in the European Union (IMY, 2026). The main purpose of GDPR is to protect the individuals' rights and privacy as they contribute with private information (IMY, 2026). With this in mind, it was of high importance to inform each respondent about the thesis, its content, and how personal data was handled. This was made by sending out an informed consent agreement well in advance before the interview was set and highlighted during the entire process of anonymity. In the consent form, the university's rules and principals regarding data collection and the possibility to withdraw without consequences were stated. Additionally, where one could take part of the study.

Since the participants represent their organization, it can be difficult to either get an honest response and that it may ethically be wrong towards the organization. Therefore, it was of high importance to advocate for anonymity. This was stated in the informed consent agreement as well as in the beginning of the interview, and lastly pseudonyms were used to maintain the anonymity of the individual and the organization (See Tabell 1). Once the research has been completed and approved, all data will be erased to further ensure security for the individual and in accordance with GDPR.

However, Brinkmann and Kvale (2005) refer to the fact that ethics during qualitative research are not mainly about standard procedures like informed consent, anonymity, etc. It is about seeing and accepting people as they are and not forcing one's own ideas and thoughts on them by understanding their social context, community, and differences (Brinkmann & Kvale, 2005, p. 161). This is an area of improvement for interviewers during this thesis. To enable a safe and relaxed environment in the beginning before initiating the interview through having small talk before being professional. This was something that the interviewers learnt along each interview that passed, towards the end, it was made sure to have an informal talk before getting started with the interview to ease and make the participants feel safe, resulting in more in-depth answers. Ethics is not only about rules, but also about being respectful, building trust, and human interaction with participants.

Furthermore, to ensure transparency in communication each participant were informed with the purpose of the research, which was to investigate how managers balance digital transformation with employees work related well-being, with the focus on managerial decision making and its effect on employee motivation, job-satisfaction, and employee performance. No further information was handed out as we did not want the participants to form reflections based on expectations and remain unbiased. Furthermore, once the findings chapter had been completed and all the citations were included, each respondent was contacted to confirm their own quotations. This felt important to the authors of the thesis to ensure credibility, accuracy, and ethical integrity. Furthermore, respondent validation increases the validity of empirical findings.

Along with keeping ethical implications in mind, it is important to be critical to one's approach as there can be some common issues arising with it. Bell et al. (2019, p. 374) opposes some of the disadvantages of qualitative research and states that the findings can sometime rely too heavily on the researcher's view, occasionally even on the relationships that grow between the researcher and participants. Because qualitative research is naturally unstructured, researchers tend to focus on what appeals to be significant to them (Bell et al., 2019, p. 374). This can be applied to the conductions of this thesis, as it is based on an interpretivism view in an ontological assumption which makes the researchers' values impactable to the thesis. In addition, one can criticize how biased the sampling of the population was as it was based on judgement and relevance to the thesis, as well as based on the researchers' networks to gain access. This can be questioned as it can affect the findings.

Furthermore, with the restriction of the number of participants, it becomes difficult to generalize the findings to other settings (Bell et al., 2019, p. 374). It can be questioned whether or not nine participants are enough to represent other cases and if five organizations can act for other organizations in the same field. Another factor that can be criticized is the disadvantages of qualitative interviews. Due to the fact that the participant is aware of being studied, it becomes less natural, and the language may differ to its normal state as a form of a reactive effect (Bell et al., 2019, p. 458). The authors (2019, p. 459) state further that qualitative interviews are limited when it comes to actual behaviors and hidden activities. Therefore, it is more difficult to reveal participants' real emotions, behaviors, and work progress as they might have been withdrawing some of the information. Participants may also avoid sharing mistakes, negative experiences, and or critical opinions due to feeling vulnerable or unconformable. This limitation can affect the overall validity and authenticity of the empirical findings.

3.7 Usage of AI

In this thesis, AI was used within limits and for certain purposes only. Firstly, AI was used when transcribing the participants' answers from the interviews. This was done through Microsoft Teams with the participants' permission. This AI tool was only used to record live responses from the interviews; all analyses and usage of the data have been made independently from the authors. Secondly, AI was utilized when translating quotes from the participant from Swedish to English, since all interviews were held in Swedish. DeepL was used for these translating purposes and was recommended to us by our supervisor. DeepL was a means for us not to translate each participant's individual quote by hand and therefore utilizing time. All translated materials and transcription have been scrutinized by us to make sure translation and meaning remain. Thirdly, digital tools including ChatGPT and Copilot was merely used to receive critical feedback regarding

the structure. This was done to have a critical opinion acting as a second supervisor to ensure relevant structure. However, it was only done through a perspective of structure. All material and all written text have been fully made by the authors, claiming the research to be done by humans.

4. Empirical Findings

This chapter presents the empirical data collected from semi-structured interviews with managers, employees, and digital transformation experts across several Swedish organizations. The findings are structured around four main analytical dimensions: organizational support, time optimization, implementation strategy, and usability, each examined from an expert, managers, and employee perspective. Each experience is shown in both quotes and summarized text.

4.1 Identified themes

This study aims to research how organizations make decisions to implement new digital systems whilst maintaining employee well-being, specifically their motivation, job satisfaction, and performance. Participants were chosen on their ability to provide insightful thoughts on the matter.

One of the requirements was to include one manager who made decisions and one to two employees from the same company. This is to ensure receiving two perspectives on the same subject and to be able to analyze how managerial decision making in digital transformation might affect employee motivation, job satisfaction, and performance. In addition, two participants were brought in to add the specialist point of view to be able to see how successful digital transformation could be done and compare that to how managers are working towards ensuring successful implementation (see Table 1).

The following sections (4.2, 4.3, 4.4, and 4.5) will be present in detail the empirical findings for each of the final themes: *organizational support, time optimization, implementation strategy and usability*. For each section, the answers of all three groups of participants will be explored in accordance with and of relevance to all the other identified themes e.g. 4.2.1 Experts perspective, 4.2.2 Managers perspective, and 4.2.3 Employee perspective and so on. The sections will be including organizational culture and managerial communication and transparency, employee efficiency and quality, the automation of repetitive tasks, managerial influence on employees' learning environment, strategic system utilization, and usage behavior. By having studied three levels of groups with different backgrounds and experience with an insight across all themes, it will initiate the necessary empirical foundation to discuss and broadly analyze in Chapter 6. Where it will be examined in depth how managerial decision-making in digital transformation will affect employee well-being specifically their motivation, job satisfaction, and performance.

Table 2. Identified themes

Final themes	Candidate themes	Argument
Organizational support	• ***Communication and transparency*** • ***Organizational culture***	For an implementation to become successful, this theme covers participants 'perception of the significance that organizational support might have through encouragement, transparency, communication, and time as a recourse to enable an increasement in employee motivation. Focusing on what experts consider relevant, how managers integrate it, and how employees receive it.
Time optimization	• ***Efficiency & quality*** • ***Automate repetitive tasks***	This theme highlights what impact technology has had on employee workload. Whether or not, users become efficient in their day-to-day work, leading to better management of their time and being able to focus on bigger, more time-consuming tasks, leading to increased quality. This will be looked at from the perspective of the experts on how they view digitalization effect efficiency, following the manager's view, and employee's actual understanding of time management after the implementation.
Implementation strategy	• ***Learning environment*** • ***Managerial influence***	This theme indicates the weight of how new digital transformations have been introduced and how it's taken in the organization. Further, it will be viewed what contributing factors can either create acceptance or resistance and how education, experts, and time can contribute. The theme will look at what experts considers important in the integration, what the manager decides regarding the implementation, and the acceptance of the employees.
Usability	• ***Strategic system utilization*** • ***Usage behavior***	To optimize usage of digital tools in organizations, this theme considers how and what the systems can be utilized for, when to and not to rely on the system, and how it can change the quality of results. From an experts perspective, it is highlighted how to actually use it and how to enhance results. The perspective of managers shows how preparation to use it is significant, while looking at how employees engage in their work when learning to use systems.

4.2 Organizational support

Organizational support emerged as a central condition of how employees experience digital transformation. Participants described support as a combination of communication and transparency that influences how employees interpret digital change. Continually explaining how experts, managers, and employees suggest, understand, and experience organizational support.

4.2.1 Experts perspective

This subsection explains how the experts discuss the meaning behind organizational support, focusing on communication, transparency, and the cultural conditions that enable employees to accept and engage with digital transformation. Experts' perspective suggests the importance of organizational support and how it adds to employee experience of the implementation.

Transparent communication embedded in the organizational culture

A recurring pattern derived from the interviews with the experts was that communication and transparency were not treated as managerial actions, rather as cultural norms that influence employee interception of digital transformation. Participants described how open communication about both benefits and limitations created a sense of honesty and safety, reinforcing a culture where uncertainty was acknowledged and not avoided. This cultural expectation of openness helped employees feel included in the process and reduced skepticism toward new systems.

"We also need to focus on change management. And change management is all about getting the general public on board, ensuring they understand and accept it. [...] and it's still an important tool for change management when it comes to how leaders work."

- *Lyckeby*

Lyckeby argues that there is more to solemnly implement AI as a technology, as it is a process including change management. The first step would be to make digital systems an availability to the employees, but then also make sure that the systems are being accepted and used by the employees. Lyckeby makes a point that change management is one way to do so, which is about getting as close to all on board with the implementation. Furthermore, leaders who work in change management act as an important tool to further enhance understanding and acceptance for implementation. This is further explained by Trelleborg:

"I believe that change management is the priority of any major change. It's like understanding, perhaps the target group, what the consequences will be for them, that is, how managers will be affected, what their situation is like today, what it will look like for them going forward, how will employees be affected, and then, based on that, try to develop a good change journey for them that includes training, messaging, in other words, reassuring them, support, follow-up, and understanding what's happening, where they are in the process, and providing the right activities at the right time. So, I think that's very important."

- *Trelleborg*

Understanding the affected group and what changes will arise for them helps develop a good change process that is well tailored for each group. Companies must first understand how different groups of people will be affected by the change, such as managers and employees, which includes understanding their current situation and how it will change in the future. Based on Trelleborg's statement, organizations benefit from creating a well-planned change process or *change journey* and should include training, clear communication, reassurance, support, and follow-up. It is important to help people feel informed and supported through the process by providing the right type of help and communication at the right time. Change management is important for conducting supportive management that meets employee skepticism and is a part of how organizations can support in the beginning of an implementation. Lyckeby adds to how to meet skepticism.

"See effects, benefits, and so on. But also, of course, highlight the downsides. Maybe you shouldn't blindly trust what you get. So that you meet them halfway in their skepticism."

- *Lyckeby*

When management communicates both benefits and the downsides with what comes along with digital implementation and new systems, organizations become more transparent and reassuring. Lyckeby states that one should not trust everything uncritically, instead it is important to acknowledge that skepticism is normal and even healthy. By discussing both sides, one can address concerns and meet people *halfway* through their doubts. This is added by Trelleborg, in which states that reassurance becomes critical in moving forward during hard times and by being transparent that everything is not perfect, even from a management perspective, it provides necessary reassurance to employees. The expert from Trelleborg mentions that through communication, one can provide reassurance, and that management wanted to forward a message that they are all in on this together through imbedding it in the organizational culture. Through teamwork, trust, and mutual support, they were facing challenges together encouraging them to stay committed and remain patient.

"Communication, trying to provide reassurance. We worked closely with management. We really tried to affirm that this is who we are. It's a tough change, not everything is 100% perfect, but this is where we're headed. So, we tried to steer toward the vision and this journey. We also tried to work a lot on change management there. Because we really tried to provide reassurance that we, who are doing this together, have each other's backs, to keep going, hold on, and persevere."

- *Trelleborg*

4.2.2 Managers perspective

This subsection examines how managers perceive their role in providing organizational support focusing on how communication and cultural norms guide their actions during transformation.

Transparent communication embedded in the organizational culture

Managers described communication as a key part of their role in supporting employees. They emphasized the importance of being present and explaining the chosen decisions. Transparent communication was seen as a way to reduce stress and uncertainties and a way for managers to showcase the purpose behind the digital change to help employees

understand the new systems. Ek in Ystad expressed what they thought to be an important factor for managers to support in a digital implementation:

"[...] maybe it's really more about being present and a source of support for one's employees. When there's a lot of new stuff going on, maybe just need to fall back on something and not feel stressed about the new implementation"

- *Ek, Ystad*

However, the manager in Ystad did not mention how the organization supported employees during the implementation. On the other hand, they stated that while management decided to implement the new systems, it was the employees who learnt themselves, and managers, how to use them. The decision to implement a new system came top down, meaning it came from senior leadership rather than being developed collaboratively from lower levels. It became younger employees' responsibility to run pilot projects and then report back their results and feedback through the organizational hierarchy to senior management.

"I guess it came from the top down. Highest management thought it was a good tool that everyone should have. But yeah. A lot of young people were put in charge of the pilot projects and had to report back up the chain."

- *Ek, Ystad*

Furthermore, Tall in Simrishamn means that in order to use the digital tools on a daily basis in work, it needs to be embedded in the organization and show employees the managerial support to do so.

"But if the goal of our work is to use it in our daily work, then we should be encouraged to do so."

- *Tall, Simrishamn*

The participants adds that it becomes a matter of organizational culture where time should be given out as a recourse to experiment with the systems being used to create a deeper knowledge and understanding amongst employees to show what the technology could be useful for. Managers highlighted that a supportive culture is one where employees are encouraged to experiment with digital tools and learn through practice. They described how culture norms that value curiosity and trial and error help employees build both competence and confidence with the systems. Managers saw their role as reinforcing these norms and creating a space for learning.

"I think it's important for an organization to encourage experimentation. Where you have to keep experimenting on your own and the need to foster an organizational culture that encourages employees to feel it's okay to experiment, tinker, and try new things."

- *Tall, Simrishamn*

Tall in Simrishamn highlights that it is not enough to only introduce a system, but employees need to feel supported and encouraged in using it regularly. The success of adoption of new tools depends largely on organizational culture, especially one that encourages experimentation. While training is useful for people working directly with the system, it is not enough on its own to make the rest of the organization adapt. Tall in Simrishamn quote illustrates that a broader adaption happens when people are encouraged to try things and see real results.

“I think it’s more of an organizational culture where you encourage experimentation because the people who actually work with D2D, they’re the ones who need to adapt, and it’s good to get training, but I don’t think that helps create adaptation for the rest of the team, you have to encourage them and show them”

- Tall, Simrishamn

4.2.3 Employee perspective

This subsection continues with how employees perceive organizational support in practice focusing on how communication and cultural expectations shape engagement with digital transformation.

Transparent communication embedded in the organizational culture

Employees described various levels of support but emphasized that communication through encouragement and shared learning or shard learning helped them shape their sense of being supported. When support was limited, employees felt that they were left to navigate the systems on their own and when communication was transparent and opened, they felt more secure in the digital change. When Lind in Ystad was asked how they perceived managerial support, the answer was the following:

“So there wasn't really any direct support, you know, other than the fact that they were behind the conference and, like, they were the ones who had brought us there.”

- *Lind, Ystad*

This indicates that other than the support in the form of conference, there was no intentional perceived managerial support from the perspective of the employee. Further, the participants state that it is encouraged to try at one's own pace to challenge oneself and use the systems. The culture involves being willing to try new things and take initiative, whilst a strong encouragement to push oneself is incorporated.

“So, I think a lot of the work is about just daring to take on things. So, I think, especially for those of us who are new, I think they want you to take those steps at your own pace. [...] but that they really encourage you to challenge yourself.”

- *Lind, Ystad*

Gran from Simrishamn explains that it is strongly encouraged by top management and operative managers, as well as within the teams to use different digital tools in the daily work. At the same time, there is pressure coming through the organization, and higher-level management is pressuring to adopt and use AI tools. This shows that the organization is embedding digital transformation and encourages to use the systems while pressuring to ensure the new technology is being implemented and used.

“[...] but I would definitely say that there is support, and they’re also feeling the pressure. I mean, my managers are getting even more pressure from higher up to make sure they use it. They are supposed to use AI and then pass that down.”

- *Gran, Simrishamn*

Rönn from Simrishamn adds to what type of support they receive from the organization. The participant state that the support is less about them encouraging or pushing them to use it and more about transparency that they are new to these systems as well, while being honest about them being in the learning phase too.

"I think everyone is pretty curious but also pretty humble about the fact that we're all beginners. I think we're all starting to try to learn together, even the leaders. They learn from us, we learn from them. The support is more that we're all trying to figure out how this actually works."

- *Rönn, Simrishamn*

However, Bok from Kivik states that sometimes it is just about accepting the fact that a new system will be implemented. The participants state that more often than not even their managers have not much to say in the top management decision-making and must go with it, do their work. Decision-making about new systems is somewhat inconsistent. Sometimes department leaders are not deeply involved in the initial decisions, making decisions made by higher level managers implemented without discussion. Employees may understand the reasoning behind these decisions, even if they do not fully agree with them, they accept that part of work life involves adapting to changes they don't always control. It conveys a sense of acceptance that some things require adjustment and flexibility. This shows the importance of having transparent communication within the organization to reassure employees and make them understand why certain changes are happening.

"It varies a bit, because I think that often my immediate supervisors or the top people in the department aren't always that involved in decisions about whether to implement a new system or something like that. But when it comes down to it, they probably just push it through and say, "This is what's going to happen…" You understand their reasoning but maybe you don't always completely agree. Then there's also, well, it's kind of like this: you put in your time, and then you kind of see that you're gaining good experience, maybe more than just everything being top-notch. And there's a lot that's good, of course. But I think there are certain things you just have to adapt to in life."

- *Bok, Kivik*

Bok in Kivik means that no matter what it is about, support and encouragement from above and higher management always have a positive impact on one's own work. However, specifically on support regarding a new implementation, the participants felt that doing it together along with management gave support in a sense of value creation.

"I find it really motivating to get support and encouragement from above, no matter what the situation actually is. Whether it's about starting to use a tool or just in general… I think it's incredibly valuable to be able to sit down and test things out together."

- Björk, Kivik

4.3 Time optimization

Time optimization was deemed a central aspect of digital transformation. Explaining how employees allocate time and effort, prioritize tasks, and perceive their own outcome in

performance. Participants state how atomization and efficacy influence both workload and the perceived quality of the work. This section describes how experts, managers, and employees understand time optimization in relation to digital tools.

4.3.1 Exprts perspective

This explains how experts understand time optimization and how automization and efficiency improvements reshape productivity and decision quality.

Automatization as a driver of efficiency and improved work quality

Experts highlight that automating repetitive tasks significantly increase productivity and can make more time for more advanced work. They described how digital tools can enhance workflow and therefore improve the quality of the work. When the expert was asked about if digitalization is affected and in what way it was, Lyckeby answered that digital tools can massively improve productivity.

"I can really tell that there's a huge difference in how much work I get done now compared to a few years ago."

- *Lyckeby*

This shows that the participant argues for digital systems, when using them right, being a source to efficiency. Lyckeby highlights that they feel their work being up to 20 times more effective by producing in larger quantities. However, the quote shows that the digital tools is not alone in making the work more efficient, it is also about putting in a lot of effort and working very hard to achieve it. When understanding how to use a system and conditioning it accordingly along with personal effort, the work force can increase significantly.

"I think I'm probably producing almost 20 times more today than I did before. But that's because I'm really, really working hard at it."

- *Lyckeby*

Lyckeby adds further that even collogues of theirs share the same perception, that digital tools advocate for enhanced efficiency.

"It's a really great tool that helps them be more efficient. "

- *Lyckeby*

Another point of view that is brought up by Trelleborg is that digital systems act as a way to improve decisions and make them better. When basing a decision on clear data, it ends up giving more quality to the decision, thus becoming more reliable.

"If you come well-prepared to present with clear data, then it's obviously easier to make decisions. I think the decisions end up being better, too."

- *Trelleborg*

We then asked the participant to clarify whether or not they meant that "*decisions end up being better*" is that it increases the quality of the decision, Trelleborg clarified that yes, decision being better means that their quality have increased.

“Absolutely.”

- *Trelleborg*

4.3.2 Managers perspective

Through managers' interviews, this section highlights how time is better divided and what it essentially means for their work as well as the organizations.

Automatization as a driver of efficiency and improved work quality

Managers describe how digital tools reduce time for routine tasks, thus helping managers complete their tasks quicker and with fewer resources. They noted that tasks that before the change required more people over multiple days could now be completed in hours. Allowing a shift in attention to more meaningful tasks and therefore improving the quality of the work. Managers' perspective on how time was distributed after an implementation was fairly positive due to the fact that most of the systems allowed better time management and enabled themselves, and employees, the opportunity to focus on other more time-consuming tasks. Ek in Ystad expressed that what you felt towards the systems based a lot on how much time you were able to save.

“Yeah, it really did save a lot of time. It was really the time efficiency that had a huge impact on how you felt.”

- *Ek, Ystad*

The participant continued to say that once being more efficient in work by using systems for different tasks, quality came to be a price. By dividing time amongst tasks in a better way, it allowed resourceful time to engage in other more significant aspects of work. It was described as follows.

“I think quality is an improvement because you have time to think about many other, more important aspects.”

- *Ek, Ystad*

In the organization of Simrishamn, Tall had similar answers. The manager states that with the implementation of technology, the efficiency of the work has increased. The participant continues to point out that progress can be made with less people in fewer days. Implying that technology does not only at the same time but can help allocate resources such as time and people to be used in a more efficient manner.

“I think things have gone significantly faster, especially because we can get more done with fewer people. In the past, when we had greater needs, we might have had five or six people working on it at the same time. Now, one other person and I can get something done in two days.”

- *Tall, Simrishamn*

Not only are systems enabling better automate tasks, but it allows for work to breed in a much faster way than before by allocating fewer days and even hours to produce and finish an assignment. Before digitalization, it could take up to between three days to one week to finish a certain task while now time is brought down to a few hours a day, collaborating with a colleague.

"And it was basically just me and then another person who maybe put in an hour a day or so of productive time and with that kind of work in the past, it would have taken, well, maybe anywhere from three days to a week."

- *Tall, Simrishamn*

The participant further explains that because of better time management with digital tools it also correlates to a positive well-being since the employees now can prioritize different tasks that are deemed more of value compared to before. Because certain work assignments can be done much faster than before, people don't need to spend as much time on routine or repetitive tasks. Instead, a focus can be placed on more important, high-level work that requires judgment or strategy and can be able to think more strategically and *from a higher level* than before, generating more meaningfulness.

"But right now, things are moving much faster, so that also has a positive impact on well-being, you might not have to spend as much time on those kinds of tasks, but instead can focus on what's important, given that the person providing input can now look at it from a higher level than before."

- *Tall, Simrishamn*

4.3.3 Employee perspective

Further, the employee perspective visualizes how they experience automatization of repetitive tasks as well as how efficiency shapes their daily work.

Automatization as a driver of efficiency and improved work quality

Employees explain how digital tools help them finish their work tasks faster and can therefore prioritize other complex areas. They pointed out digitalization as something that both increases efficiency and work quality, but it was dependent on how clearly the systems were introduced. Otherwise, it can work in the other direction and become more time consuming instead. Björk, Kivik brings the employee perspective and highlights when digital tools are being used; it provides insightful answers quickly. The participant describes that the same task would have been much more time consuming if they had done it themselves manually; however now it provides a quicker result.

"[...] but yes, otherwise it's just a way to quickly and easily come up with a solution that might otherwise have taken me much, much longer to do manually"

- *Björk, Kivik*

Another participant adds to the previous one, pressing on how using the digital tool from the beginning makes them much more effective, giving the participant the opportunity to analyze the result for quality rather than starting from the top. The perception of Gran in Simrishamn states that systems allow them to be more efficient in their work, which helps them in the long run by focusing on more time-consuming or difficult tasks.

"My work quality improves because I can devote time to tasks, in other words, I can manage my time better, I'd say and my efficiency increases. It's faster, of course, and you become more efficient and can focus a bit on other things"

- *Gran, Simrishamn*

This statement is supported by another employee from the same organization. Highlighting that systems and technology allow them to save more time and enable them to focus on other more time consuming as well as challenging tasks. By becoming more

efficient, they free up the capacity to do more work or shift their attention to more complex and valuable work in the future.

"But also the long-term benefit of saving a huge amount of time, which in the long run allows me to spend time on more tasks or even more challenging tasks."

- *Rönn, Simrishamn*

Along with both employees stating that their time management is becoming better and more efficient, it leads to an increasement in the quality of their results. The second employee adds that while quality increases, it is still of value to double-check the results given from the system as it sometimes can produce mistakes. The participants describe enhanced efficiency and quality since the implementation of digital tools, Rönn, Simrishamn points to feeling an increase in quality of their work while Gran, Simrishamn adds its own feeling of being more effective with the correlation of time management. In general, the implementation of digital transformation has had an impact on employee's usage of time and perceived excellence in their work. In most cases both groups showcase significant improvement of efficiency, being able to finish work task days earlier, and distributing their time more productively.

"So I think the quality will be higher. But you still need to have a bit of a knack for it and a keen eye, too."

- *Rönn, Simrishamn*

However, Lind, Ystad adds that digital transformation would lead to time savings and the participant to being more motivated if clearer ways of using the tool were demonstrated. Lind, Ystad describes that in more complex cases AI is more time consuming than time optimizing. In the way of asking the right question and getting the right answer. The participant describes this can take multiple steps, with having to send screenshots and thorough explanations for the AI to understand the given task. Thus, decreasing the participants' feelings of work efficiency takes more time than it saves. This shows that while digital tools could be useful, it can sometime feel inefficient when the interaction requires more explanation to even understand the desired outcome.

"Well, in a way, I suppose I would have become a more motivated user if they'd shown me more ways to do it like this is an effective method that could actually save a lot of time and produce good results. But now I feel like I think it's pretty time-consuming to ask the AI the questions I would have needed to ask in that case, and I would have had to provide a lot of screenshots in many different steps, just to even explain what I mean to the AI, even if it's only prompted to Ystad, I think it would have turned out that way. It feels more time-consuming, or rather, inefficient to ask specifically about those kinds of system-related questions."

- Lind, Ystad

4.4 Implementation strategy

Implementation strategy shapes how digital transformation is received and integrated into daily work. Participants describe how environments that enable learning and structured decision-making can determine whether employees feel prepared and supported for the digital change. Further presenting how experts, managers and employees understand implementation strategy.

4.4.1 Expert perspective

Continuing with how experts conceptualize implementation strategy with regard to learning environment and managerial influence as important aspects to consider getting a successfully implemented digital transformation.

Managerial environments that enable digital learning

Experts describe to get a successful implementation of digitalization managers should actively shape the organizational environment. They explained that managers should provide training and practical guidance to build competence. Managerial influence was seen as a key figure for getting acceptance and helping employees understand the new digital tools. To initiate a digital transformation to an organization, it takes a lot of decision-making from managers to implement a strategy to make this transformation successful. We started by looking at how experts believed digital tools to be used during the managerial decision-making process. Trelleborg reports that availability in data facilitates decision-making by motivating it with data and not human judgement. The participants believe that the decision will be clearer when it's based in facts and will also generate a better outcome. Instead of using people's perspective, feelings, and words to make a decision, managers can now present thorough explanations on why one decision is more fitted than another.

"It's easier to push through decisions or make well-informed decisions when we have data and things like that. It might be easier to argue for taking this approach or to demonstrate why. It doesn't become a matter of one person's word against another's, or gut feelings, or someone expressing an opinion without really knowing what it's based on. If you come prepared to present with clear data, then it's easier to make decisions. I think the decisions will be better, too."

- *Trelleborg*

The participant continues with explaining the impact of the digital change, that before one would be more dependent on managers' experience, but now digitalization has opened for more alternatives showing and evidence-based decisions that can provide better outcomes. People have more options and are not as dependent on a single expert opinion and instead different alternatives can be compared, leading them to be supported with facts and evidence. A shift happens from relying mainly on authority and experience to making decisions based on multiple data-backed alternatives.

"So maybe that's how it was before, but back then you were perhaps more reliant on trusting certain people. That this person with extensive experience says this, and then you have to go with it. Now we might have more options, we can present alternatives 1, 2, and 3 and back them up with well-founded facts. "

- *Trelleborg*

While Trelleborg advocates data-based decisions in a digital implementation, the participant also highlights not forgetting the need to bring in other human perspectives to check out the decisions that have been made to ensure not having missed something valuable and significant. This illustrates that while data-driven decisions are important, they should still be balanced with human insight and different viewpoints to make more complete decisions.

"And depending on what it is, we may need other perspectives. We've been thinking about this based on what we see in the data, but is there something we've missed? Even though we make data-driven decisions where it's relevant to incorporate other perspectives."

- *Trelleborg*

Trelleborg then discusses implementation strategy of digitalization that allows acceptance and highlights that it is important with a straightforward strategy to present what goals the organization is aiming achieve, how they will be achieved and then to follow it up. The right culture within the organization and a clear strategy advocate for an environment where a clear structure helps during the process of the implementation.

"Have a clear structure that includes goals, follow-up, how everything is run, and so on, combined with the right people and the right culture within the program."

- *Trelleborg*

Lyckeby adds to Trelleborg's view of the importance of a strategy and points to AI competence as a gradual process involving different levels of understanding as it can be challenging getting people to adapt. First, one needs to be exposed to the systems by trying it out. Then, one needs to be good at it and lastly, one will experience the output of the implementation of technology. The quote illustrates that adoption grows gradually; first by using the systems, then comes skill, and finally meaningful results.

"It's hard to get many people to start using it. So there are different levels to it. First, you have to start using it. Then you have to get good at it. Once you're good at it, you get a lot out of it."

- *Lyckeby*

When applying these steps to introduce technology, Lyckeby adds that competence building is also about educating about what it is as well as how to use. This can be done through training sessions where employees learn more about the systems and receive a navigating system on how different systems can be used to achieve desired results.

"We ran a few training sessions, and part of what we did was explain how it works. So it wouldn't be completely unfamiliar. "Oh, this is just a little black box that spits out words." Without them understanding what it's all about. And then you also show them examples. If you type this, you get roughly this result. But try rewriting it this way and then they saw that they got a completely different, much better answer. I think that's very valuable."

- *Lyckeby*

To meet potential resistance and drawbacks from the employees regarding the new systems, that Lyckeby mentioned, the participant proposes the importance of not ignoring criticism or hesitance, instead as a leader one must meet them in it by being transparent with both benefits and disadvantages. This shows that decisions about new digital systems can be met with initial skepticism. Especially when people have not learned how it works yet, it might create insecurity.

"But also, of course, to highlight the downsides. Maybe you shouldn't blindly trust what you're told. So that you can meet them halfway in their skepticism."

- *Lyckeby*

Later in the interview, Lyckeby adds again how significant it is for a large organization to work on employee skill development once decisions are made to implement

digitalizing. It will not be enough to solemnly give employees access to the system; they need right competence and knowledge of how to use it for them to gain efficiency and productivity that digital tools actually bring along.

"If you're going to transition an entire company that is, a somewhat larger company, it's not just a matter of giving them a login and calling it a day. It's about getting them up and running, training them, and making sure they actually understand and use the system effectively and productively."

- *Lyckeby*

4.4.2 Manager perspective

This subsection views how managers describe their role in implementation strategy with the focus on creating a working learning environment that influences the acceptance of digital implementation.

Managerial environments that enable digital learning

Managers convey the importance of staying informed about new systems to understand their impact on employees, highlighting involvement in training and follow ups to identify challenges and give the right support to hinder resistance. We asked managers how the implementation of digitalizing looked like in each organization, how it was received from employees, and what they did to handle resistance. Ystad Ek answered that there was some training in the beginning, education and because of the ever evolution of technology, it becomes an ongoing process.

"We did get some training on them at the beginning through the guidance documents, but things are constantly evolving, so it's a continuous process. I don't know, there are tons of training courses out there. Maybe I just haven't taken them all."

- *Ek, Ystad*

The participant proceeds to say that since it is a big firm, it was not mandatory for everyone to attend. Instead, it was an introduction via Teams platform that everyone was informed and encouraged to attend.

"No, since it's such a big company, it was kind of like a Teams briefing that everyone was encouraged to attend or watch. It wasn't mandatory."

- *Ek, Ystad*

However, Ek from Ystad states the significance of being involved in an implementation as a manager to develop an overview and understanding regarding what is going on in the organization, thus what affects it has on their employees. By having enough insight to stay informed, it helps managers maintain an overview of what is happening and understand the broader context of the organization's activities.

"I think it's good to have some insight into what's being implemented. Just to keep a general overview. I'm not deeply involved in all the services we offer. But it's still good to have some insight so you can understand what's going on."

- *Ek, Ystad*

Further, when Ek in Ystad was asked how their managerial perspective was on employee resistance, it was stated that they would firstly like to see their employees give it a try. However, the participant argued for the importance of following up, evaluating, and reviewing what has worked respectively not worked, what and how certain digital tools can be improved.

"[...] to give it a try but then follow up and evaluate how it went to see if they can get some newer tools or parts. And in our view, it's very much a matter of evaluating what has worked and what hasn't, to see if improvements can be made."

- *Ek, Ystad*

Overall, Ek in Ystad viewed the implementation positively while still acknowledging the fact that it will always be challenging when something new comes along and is being introduced.

"I think we all thought it was really good. That's my take on the whole thing. Then again, it's always tough when something new comes along."

- *Ek, Ystad*

Tall, Simrishamn points out AI as a technology that is necessary for their operation but a difficult procedure to implement. The participant emphasizes that a practical, yet easy walkthrough of the system is missing. This highlights that while the goal is clear, to use digital systems, there is less clarity on how to actually do it in practice. The lack of support makes it challenging to turn the usage of digital tools into everyday working methods. The Tall, Simrishamn further goes into that the higher level in the hierarchy cannot operate AI themselves, which according to the participant becomes a gap between advocating for its usage but lacking its competence.

"We have to use AI. We have to become an AI-driven organization; we have to use AI in our operations. That's important. We have to focus on AI. But then there's the question of how to actually do it. So there's a lack of something simple and a bit more hands-on when it comes to how to actually implement it. [...] There are senior executives who say we have to use AI, but they barely know what AI is themselves."

- *Tall, Simrishamn*

It is stated that the difference in understanding comes from the fact that not everyone has had much time to experience or work with these tools. Because of that, some people are more confident and knowledgeable, while others are still uncertain about how to use them effectively. The participant adds that it becomes unclear amongst employees in the organization on how the technology or certain digital tools can be used, since there is no education or time to experiment with them.

"I think it's a bit unclear to many people in the organization how to use it, and there's a bit of difference when it comes to understanding what the tools can do, since they haven't worked with them much or experimented with them before."

- *Tall, Simrishamn*

We proceeded to ask the participant what factors they could identify to understand why everyone in the organization might not use the technology provided to them. Tall in Simrishamn answers that there is no education for employees on how to use it to receive desired outcomes and because it might for some people, be more difficult without the hands-on examples. While the participants acknowledged that the availability of online courses was there, they did not think it was enough for employees to learn how to use the digital tools correctly. Tall in Simrishamn stated that the users often use it, but when they do not receive desired results, they face a dead end and end up not knowing how to proceed. Practical and clear guidance is missing, which leads to a misusage of the system and employees end up receiving an unsatisfactory result. This stops them from continuing to use it effectively.

"It's one thing to have training, but when it's such a big company, it's a bit like this I mean, there has to be a slide that says here are steps 1, 2, 3, 4, 5. This is what you do in step 1. This is what you do in 2, 3, 4, 5. And I haven't seen it that simple… because I've noticed that when I've seen some people who maybe haven't worked much with AI, they go in and type, "I want this." Then when they get the result, "Okay, that's not what I wanted; I don't know what to do.""

- *Tall, Simrishamn*

Furthermore, the participant adds what they are missing in the implementation and reflects that someone is needed to be brought in to enable learning and training of how to use the tools. This emphasizes the importance of an expert demonstrating what is possible and showing practical ways of using the systems. When people can see successful examples, they are more likely to adapt and follow the same approach.

"The foundation is that you need some kind of learning and training. If you want to adapt, you need someone to demonstrate what can be done so that others can follow suit."

- *Tall, Simrishamn*

4.4.3 Employee perspective

Further employee perspective looks at how employees experience the digital implementation strategy, what influences shapes their engagement with the new systems.

Managerial environments that enable digital learning

Employees imply that the role of managerial and organizational support is crucial to their adaptability and learning experience. However, most employees expressed that more often than not the management in middle hierocracy is rarely involved in the decision that takes regarding new systems and digital tools. When decisions are made by top management that include new digital transformation, it is communicated as something that is established rather than something opened for suggestment. When introducing new digital solutions, it can provide challenges and create a hindrance for employees to adapt to the new processes. Bok, Kivik describes that sometimes it is just to accept new introductions, and the initial feeling from management is to accept it or leave.

"I think that often my immediate supervisors or the top people in the department aren't always that involved in decisions about whether to implement a new system or something like that. They tend to make more strategic decisions for the department and so on. But when it comes down to it, they probably just go along with it and say, "This is how it's

going to be." This is what we're going to do." Then, yeah, like I said, they make more strategic decisions for the department—whatever they think is best for it."

- *Bok, Kivik*

However, Björk in Kivik perceives more encouragement from management to use the technology and digital tools. The participant describes that a large focus in organizations is on digital transformation and is encouraged by top management to utilize it in day-to-day work. This further implies an uncertainty and inconsistency to how information and education are disturbed within the organization, making the perception different.

"The focus is on digitalization and AI tools. They're working really hard on those areas, and they want us to make the most of them because it really makes everything, we do more efficient."

- *Björk, Kivik*

The same employee from Kivik explains their integration process of how competence building withing digital transformation has been put forward with education on specific scenarios and when it can be applicable to different tasks.

"And then there have been a few training sessions, lunch meetings, and optional training sessions where they explain how to use it. Then we had our own training session, specifically for my team, on how we can apply it to the work we're currently doing."

- *Björk, Kivik*

Gran in Simrishamn discusses the range of education provided by the organization. The participant states that there are training sessions available in their databases, weekly workshops, and hands-on courses where they learn how to do certain tasks with the help of technology.

"There's quite a bit of self-directed learning going on. For example, I know that our AI team here they hold AI workshops every week where you learn about the new topic for the week. And then there are also more hands-on courses where you actually meet in person and get to work on building an AI agent or tackle different case studies."

- *Gran, Simrishamn*

The participant proceeds to discuss that it sometimes becomes difficult to understand where the digital courses can be found on how to use the systems. At the same time as it is encouraged to learn and use technology, it is challenging to understand and find information about these opportunities. As the communication and accessibility around training programs are not clear, it is not easy to navigate through it.

"But sometimes I think it can be hard to figure out where these training programs are. [...] so you might have to look them up yourself or ask a colleague or something. It's not always super clear how to find training in that system."

- *Gran, Simrishamn*

Rönn in Simrishamn agrees that it is a lot of self-learning, which is not always the easiest way. Since it is not very clear on new systems being implemented, it becomes difficult to know where to find them.

"A lot of what the organization does relies on people taking the initiative and either organizing and running a course like that or attending one. [...] and then it's really up to you to get involved."

- *Rönn, Simrishamn*

On the other hand, Gran in Simrishamn later adds that it can become overwhelming with that many systems and learn new systems. When there are many different systems to manage, and new tools or updates are introduced frequently, it becomes demanding. Because of new updates, employees are expected to continuously learn new things and complete various training sessions. Keeping up with all these updates and learning requirements can lead to exhaustion.

"As an employee, I sometimes feel a little overwhelmed by how many different systems there are and how there's always something new coming up. And there are so many updates to learn, I mean, you have to go through all these training sessions and stuff."

- *Gran, Simrishamn*

Lind from Ystad explained that they also had a few training sessions where the systems were introduced and encouraged to be used. Despite the introduction of lectures, Lind, Ystad highlights that in the beginning it was difficult to get an understanding of the system. The participant describes that there can be a contrast of competence between the people who have worked there longer as opposed to those who were newcomers. Lind, Ystad states that this can make it challenging to know what individual employees have for knowledge. Because people have different levels of experience within the organization, it can be challenging to understand how things work and to know what knowledge is supposed to be had. It makes it more difficult to adjust to a complex environment and systems.

"We had two full days where there were various lectures and such. [...] At first, I didn't know how to navigate the system. I mean, we have people who've been working here for four years, three years, two years, and then people like us who just started, which makes it pretty hard to get the hang of. Or maybe it's just a little hard to keep track of exactly what everyone is capable of."

- *Lind, Ystad*

Further, Lind, Ystad adds what would have been wanted from the management for a really enhanced understanding of the systems. The participants would have appreciated an extremely thorough review of understanding the digital tool and how to utilize it. These facilities that managers can influence and create an environment for employees to learn and understand how to use systems in daily work and affect a lot of the acceptance of employees.

"...an overemphasis on clarity, especially for us newcomers, or perhaps something tailored specifically for us who might not be used to this kind of thing or know how to find all the information."

- *Lind, Ystad*

4.5 Usability

Usability affects how employees interact with digital tools in practice, and participants describe how strategic system utilization and usage behavior influences the effectiveness of digital transformation. Explaining further how experts, managers, and employees understand usability.

4.5.1 Expert perspective

The experts perspective focuses on how they understand usability with the areas of strategic system utilization and the behavior that emerges from it.

System utilization driving employee usage behavior

Experts point out that usability depends on how and when digital tools should be used. Describing that strategic use can help employees achieve better outcomes and avoid overreliance and in turn shape employees when interacting with digital tools. Lyckeby points out that when employees see the intended use and of how the system can be used in practice, the willingness to engage in the technology will grow. It is further explained that the usage increases when the discovery of potential benefits is apparent. When the user sees the value in the system, it will lead to a more active usage of the system and starting to feel a bit more comfortable with it.

"Once those insights click into place, I think interest will grow. [...] Once you start to see the potential and the benefits, you start using it a little bit. Then you get into it. Yeah, and you start advocating for it a bit more."

- *Lyckeby*

A misconception about digitization is that one should use it as a last resort, when in fact, according to Lyckeby, it is much more effective, and you receive better results if you use it in the beginning of the tasks. To use digital tools early in the process, it becomes a tool for quickly brainstorming ideas and gaining directions. This creates a more effective way of using the systems as it helps keep momentum and forward faster. Perfection is less important than begins somewhere, in other words digitalization is valuable as a support tool for progress instead of producing perfect results immediately.

"I think, generally speaking, that many people use it as a last resort, they try and try and try then "No, I can't think of anything else now; I'm stuck. Now I'll turn to AI." And then you get a little help. I'm the opposite, and I think that's how you're most effective bouncing ideas off an AI quickly and then pushing forward. The most important thing is to get the right direction, not to land everything perfectly."

- *Lyckeby*

Lyckeby advocates again for the importance of teaching how to use the technology, as it is a key understanding that will give value to one's work. The quality of responses generating from systems depends largely on how users phrase their prompts or questions. By showing the employees how to write a request, the digital tool can help produce a completely different and better response. This shows that communication with the systems matter as well-structured instructions gives better outcomes.

"If you write it this way, you get a result like this. But try rewriting it this way. And then they saw that they got a completely different, much better answer. I think that's very valuable because it helps you understand that it actually matters how you communicate with a generative AI model."

- *Lyckeby*

However, Lyckeby adds while working with familiarizing the employees with the new system to get them to advocate it; the expert also underlines the importance of not only taking the AIs decision blindly. The user of the systems also needs to be skeptical about the results that are being produced and must control the outcome to ensure its quality so

that the content stands. This emphasizes that digital tools are often better at providing inspiration and ideas than at completing an assignment, therefore the tools should be seen as a support system to human work rather than a replacement that can independently do the entire job.

"AI is making rapid progress. But on the other hand, you can't just blindly trust it… you have to ensure quality, and it might inspire more than it actually produces. And that you see it as an assistant rather than a colleague that does your work. "

- *Lyckeby*

Trelleborg adds that whilst they provide data-based decisions with digital tools, they still include a human perspective to foresee if anything has been missed and thus works with both digitalization and human judgement as data alone may not provide a complete picture. An ongoing effort should be incorporated to balance data-based information with human insight and alternative viewpoints. To maximize effectiveness in decision-making, one should combine data analysis with broader perspectives to ensure more complete conclusions.

"[...] based on what we see in the data, but we need other perspectives to understand, is there something we've missed? I would say that's something we're always working on, even though we make data-driven decisions, whenever it's relevant to incorporate other perspectives."

- *Trelleborg*

4.5.2 Manager perspective

This subsection focuses on how managers perceive usability and how guidance and planning influences how the employees will utilize the systems.

System utilization driving employee usage behavior

Managers describe how the employees will behave when using the systems relies on how well they interpret the purpose and understand what they can get out of it. When systems are linked to meaningful tasks and can be demonstrated how to improve outcome, employees engage with them more. When creating engagement for the new systems, how to use it is of essence. Tall, Simrishamn explains that users without experience of AI can have problems formulating what they want out of the system, which can affect the quality they get on their results.

"I've seen some people who haven't worked much with AI they go in and type, 'I want this,' and then they get the result and say, 'Okay, that's not what I wanted…' It has to be super simple for people to be able to do it themselves."

- *Tall, Simrishamn*

Further, Tall, Simrishamn describes the need for simplicity to make employees utilize the systems and can determine if a person uses it or not. If the system is believed to be too complex, it will take away efficiency rather than enhance it.

"I'd say that ease of use is perhaps the biggest factor, if it feels too unwieldy because you have to click too much and enter a lot of different information and details, then it feels a bit more complicated."

- *Tall, Simrishamn*

If the usability is handled, the participant explains what one can get out of it. This shows the participant increased engagement with the ability to see what one can produce and offer to the client. The participant gets an understanding of the systems' value and produces high quality results in the form of interactive participants that had before the systems been an impossibility. Making it more user-friendly, it encourages the employee to keep performing better and deliver quality-based results.

"I've built a website where the client and I can walk through and click on each step and say what should be in each step. So from that perspective, what we can do in terms of making it even more client-friendly, you could say."

- *Tall, Simrishamn*

While digital tools are used in decision-making, it is still the human judgment that finalizes what way to proceed. The technology can be viewed as support and not replacement for the decisions that are made, which is what Ekin Ystad explains.

"But in the end, it's still human interaction that drives the decisions. [...] both are needed to make a good decision."

- *Ek, Ystad*

Ek, Ystad proceeds to state that it is how easy a system is to use that will be the main factor to employee's usage of it, especially when time is of essence. Despite the fact that the more advanced system might give better and more quality based results.

"Everyone will choose an easy-to-use tool over a advanced one, even if the advanced tool might produce better results."

- *Ek, Ystad*

We then asked if they thought employees would use the advanced tool if it was shown what it can produce; the immediate answer was yes. This shows that a proper educational environment can facilities the usage of an advanced tool and contribute to a higher level of quality results.

"Yes."

- *Ek, Ystad*

4.5.3 Employee perspective

Continuing with how employees understand how they can utilize the systems and how it can contribute to learning and active participation.

System utilization driving employee usage behavior

Employees highlight that their usage behavior can evolve when they learn how digital tools bring value and further pinpoints hands on learning and experimentation as a contributing factor. To ensure usability and engagement for the employees, Björk, Kivik explains that upper management demonstrates and has exercises where the systems can be tried and explored. The participant feels that this brings value and understanding of how the functions can be applicable in their work.

"Then the leaders go over what we can do with it, how we can use it,

demonstrate it, and let us try it out. I think it adds a lot of value to be able

to sit down and test things out together."

- *Björk, Kivik*

Although the same participant also states that if it is not easy to use and can't be understood then some might not use it at all. Which showcases that employees use simpler systems because it is easier to understand, rather than a more complicated system that generates better results as no education has been given.

"It has to be super simple for people to be able to do it themselves. There's a barrier for some people they're not really comfortable working with it and don't quite understand it."

- *Björk, Kivik*

Another participant also highlights management's involvement in the form of getting their employees to utilize the system. At the same time, the participant also state that management also encourages them to examine the given outcome from the system to make sure they are correct. On the other hand, even if the participant perceive encouragement from management to check the results themselves, they sometimes give out directions that AI should be used for specific tasks. So, there is a mixture of autonomy and direction where employees are both encouraged to think for themselves but at the same time, they may receive instructions on which tools to utilize for specific tasks.

"I'd say that management encourages us to think for ourselves, but as I mentioned, sometimes you're given a task and they'll write something like, 'Use ChatGPT for this.'"

- *Gran, Simrishamn*

Lind in Ystad adds that it is highly motivating when they feel like they can contribute something to the organizations and have a bigger and contributing role. The participant also adds that when understanding the system, it becomes easier to help and support the rest of the team, which adds to their motivation. This shows that motivation comes from gaining skills, becoming more capable, and feeling like they play a bigger part in what the organization produces as it gives a sense of contribution.

"I'd say it's really motivating now that I can do it myself. It's just that feeling you can contribute, help others, and support the group. That's what motivates me and just knowing that. It's that you can take on those kinds of tasks, so you become a bit more well-rounded and feel like you're playing a bigger role."

- *Lind, Ystad*

On the other hand, it is considered and perceived as more motivating and would make the participant more engaged if there was a more thorough explanation on how or more ways to use the systems for. If it was shown how a certain way could enhance their work, it would create an increased motivation to actually use the systems. Methods on how to save time and lead to good results would be found more valuable if demonstrated nuanced by managers. It led to a better adaption to have seen a concrete example of usefulness which increases motivation.

"Well, in a way, I'd probably have become a more motivated user. I mean, if they'd shown me more ways to do use it. This is an effective method that would actually save a lot of time and produce good results. Then I'd have been like, "Wow, that's great, I'd definitely have used it."

- *Lind, Ystad*

Table 3. Conclusion of findings

Conclusion of findings	**Experts**	**Manager**	**Employee**
Organizational support	It is necessary for organizations to conduct a digital implementation and understand it from an employee's perspective.	When it is imbedded in the organization culture, it becomes encouraged to use.	When receiving managerial support and encouragement, it results in using systems more frequently.
Time optimization	When using digital tools in a resourceful way, it can become an efficient tool to manage different daily tasks.	Efficiency increases and the same tasks requires now less time and people leading to better time management.	When understanding how to use the tools, it enables better use of time. It becomes efficient by receiving quicker results, leading to increased quality.
Implementation strategy	A successful implementation is dependent on data driven decision-making with employee education to minimize resistance.	Digital transformation is necessary but can be challenging to operate in practice.	Encouragement, continuous training sessions, and clear communication are needed to ensure a positive perception of the implementation.
Usability	Digital transformation requires training in how the systems can be used to make sure organizations are engaged in the implementation.	Managers point out the importance of simple usage of the systems to ensure the value of the results.	If the systems appear easy to use, they are encouraged by management and give quality in outcomes it becomes motivational for the worker.

5. Analysis and discussion

This chapter presents the understanding of the empirical findings in connection to the theoretical framework and aiming to explain how managerial decision-making during digital transformation affects employee motivation, satisfaction, and performance. The chapter is further centered around two major components: how managers make decisions in a digitalized environment, and how these decisions influence employee motivation, satisfaction, and performance. Further, this chapter includes findings connected to the conceptual framework and a revised conceptual framework.

5.1 Managerial decision-making during digital transformation

From the findings across experts, managers, and employees, several consistence findings emerged (see Table 3). Digital transformation implies changed conditions managers operate in. Manager must navigate uncertainty and quick technological developments. This was supported by the findings of all three levels of participants that digital transformation is not simply about introducing a digital tool; it is merely organizational change. This change involves managerial communication and transparency, reassurance, leadership, training and education, and cultural adaption. Findings indicate that employees need to understand why a new system is introduced, practical value, and support to experiment with it. Further, the findings suggest that managers leading during digital transformation regards active engagement, guidance, communication openly, and acknowledge difficulties that may arise. Adaption arises from experiencing benefits such as what the tool provides, how much time is being saved, efficiency, and work quality that enhance the meaningfulness of work contributions. Nevertheless, while digitalization is proven by both theory and the empirical findings that it is a positively enforced tool, human judgment remains essential. Across all groups of participants, it is agreed that digital results must be reviewed and the importance of human oversight. Lastly, it is shown that digital tools should be seen as less of a replacement of human expertise and more as an assistant.

Further conclusion of the group participants' findings and its relevance to prior research will be presented in section 5.1.1, 5.1.2, and 5.1.3. For the relevance of this thesis, each section is divided in accordance with the group's findings and connection to previous theories and research.

5.1.1 The evolving nature of managerial decision-making in digital transformation

Earlier research shows that managerial decision-making changes during digital transformation. Simon (1955) explains that managers make decisions under limitations in information and cognitively. In a digital context, these limitations can become even more pronounced due to rapid integration of digital systems. Digitalization intensifies these limits by adding AI generated results data and information overload, which require managers to balance both their human expertise and digital input (Raisch & Krakowski, 2020; Pittenger et al., 2023). At the same time, the findings illustrate that digital tools can help managers make faster and more data-driven decisions. Therefore, it is essential that managers balance digital input with their own human expertise, judgment, and critical thinking which is aligned with the findings from Raish and Krakowski (2020) and Pittenger et al. (2023). Furthermore, empirical findings suggest that communication and

transparency become essential tools managers must navigate for reducing limitations and uncertainty in their decision-making process. These findings therefore support Simon's theory of bounded rationality (1955) by showing that although digitalization allows access to more information, managers still experience difficulties in utilizing digitalized decision-making processes effectively. Additionally, findings suggest that managerial decision-making impacts employees' acceptance to digital transformation. When managers provide the right training that facilitates understanding of the digital systems, the acceptance increases, which is analyzed further in the following text.

Continuingly, when employees are informed of the purpose of the implementation and are a part of the decisions regarding digital transformation, they are more likely to be satisfied in their work and their well-being increases (Ullrich et al., 2023). Through the findings, it is highlighted that communications and transparency are two of the most influencing factors in organizational support. This extends precious research of Ullruch et al. (2023) by indicating that transparency is not only about information sharing, but also about managing uncertainty and aligning expectations during technological change. In this sense, transparency functions as a trust-building mechanism rather than an informational tool because it reduces uncertainty and allows employees to better understand how technological changes affect their daily work roles. Findings showed clearly that managers who understand the targeted audience, what changes they will go through, communicate both benefits and downsides, and reflect transparency by meeting them in their skepticism, enhance the trust to their employees.

Furthermore, Brock and Khan (2017) discuss that it is important for organizations to have a clear structure and implementation strategy to ease the digital transformation for employees and be met with acceptance. This aligns with the findings that brings up the importance of understanding how implementation fails and includes that in the strategy to better prevent it. Organizations may fail with their digital transformation if they lack in experts' opinion on the subject which, according to Valtonen and Holopainen (2025), have a significant linkage to how managers later educate their employees in the systems leading to a factoring reason to their resistance. In the empirical findings, experts pointed out that organizations often miss out on the systems' efficiency and value because they do not have the required knowledge to teach forward. This extends previous research by showing that implementation failure is not only related to lack of technological expertise, but also to organizations' inability to translate digital systems into meaningful employee practices. If a user does not know how a system can be used or what it does, it creates resistance and employees do end up misusing it or not using it at all.

Previous research on organizational support highlights its importance for successful digital transformation as it becomes a key determinant of successful digital transformation, where leadership communication, training, and involvement are central for employee acceptance (Amoako-Gyampah & Salam, 2003; Nielsen et al., 2017). However, less is known about how support is operationalized in practice during implementation. The findings of this study extend this understanding that organizational support is not limited to access to digital systems but instead functions as a broader change management mechanism. The findings suggest that employee acceptance is shaped less by the technology itself and more about how organizational support is enacted during implementation. This implies that managerial support is not merely on giving access to technological systems; it is about change management, that is how leaders engage with their employees, ensuring their understanding, acceptance, and usage. One of the participants highlights this by stating *"training, reassuring them, support, follow-*

up and providing the right activities." Furthermore, the findings contribute to the previous literature by suggesting that organizational support should not merely be seen as a static resource, but as a dynamic process of interaction between leaders and employees during transformation.

Existing literature has identified that *openness and experimentation* is one of the ways organizations can enhance their competence regarding digitalization, thereby increasing the chances of their acceptance to the implementation (Valtonen & Holopainen, 2025). When managers give employees the opportunity to experiment with the new systems, it gives a better understanding of what the digital tools actually can do which increases employee motivation which leads to a successful implementation (Trenerry et al., 2021; Judge & Piccolo, 2004). The findings of this study support this and also add that time and experimentation should be given to the employees as a resource to let them get familiar with the new technical systems to better learn how they can use it in their professional work. Further, this implies that acceptance of digital transformation comes from using it in order to get good at it and suggest that once they do, employees get better at it and see the benefits of it. When employees understand, learn about, and start using digital tools in their work, it creates efficiency and higher quality results. Previous research (Chiva et al., 2007) highlights that efficiency is an expected outcome when implementation strategy is conveyed correctly. Findings highlighted that when a digital tool is used accurately, it can help one produce up to *"20 times more than earlier"* as one of the participants pointed out. This highlights the importance of competence development during digital transformation. Education, experts teaching in the subject, time to experiment is all vital for managers to have in mind and include in their decision regarding digitalized implementation, as it can not only create a successful implementation but also better time management and overall efficiency as well as quality. However, even though experimentation supports learning, findings also suggest that too much self-directed exploration without managerial guidance may instead contribute to technostress and uncertainty.

5.1.2 Managerial decision-making as an intermediary process

Previous researcher, Davis (1989), states that there are external factors that influence users' perceived usefulness and ease of use of technological systems. Amoako-Gyampah and Salam (2003) further signific the direct linkage between top management to employees perceived usefulness and ease of use of a system. The findings extend this understanding by positioning managers as critical intermediaries in the digital transformation process, acting as a connection between top-management and employees' daily work. Managers appear to play a central role in shaping how digital transformation is accepted within the organizations. Further findings indicate that managers are expected to both drive digital transformation and at the same time maintain employee's motivation, job satisfaction, and performance. This suggests that employee acceptance of digital technologies is influenced not only by systems, but also by how managers translate the system into meaningfulness. However, the findings also showcase that the managers themselves experience uncertainty during the implementation of digitalization. Creating a complex role for managers which further implies that managerial communication, support, and encouragement are significant in reducing uncertainty to facilitate technology acceptance.

Amoako-Gyampah and Salam (2003) add on the importance of support, claiming that managers who convey apparent communication and practice training can affect the

acceptance of the technology use to be more favored. The empiric material visualizes that the managerial support given sometimes concerns being transparent in one's communication. This extends previous research by highlighting that not to oversimplify and praise the new digital tools but instead being honest about being in the learning phase and that even managers are having a hard time adjusting. In this sense, creating a learning environment where knowledge-sharing can influence employees' motivation and acceptance.

Further, the finding highlighted that managers attempted to develop an organizational culture that encouraged curiosity and experimenting with the new systems. Organizational learning capability (OLC) discusses *Openness and experimentation* as one condition for enhanced efficiency with implementation of new technology (Brock and Khan, 2017, p. 9). The authors (2017, p. 9) continue to emphasize that being open to trying and learning new tools can lead to a good implementation of digital systems. From the findings, it is shown that some managers work continuously with building this type of culture where they want their employees to embrace this mindset. However, the empirical findings also demonstrate that not all employees were provided with the time and support needed for experimenting. Some of the employees instructed by management to figure things out for themselves regarding new systems. This extends previous literature by showing experimentation alone is not sufficient for the success of digital transformation. While openness and experimentation are often viewed as positive organizational conditions in the literature, the findings of this study indicate that experimentation without sufficient managerial support, structure or time can instead create uncertainty and frustration among employees. On the other hand, Hackman & Oldham (1976, p. 256) describe autonomy in the form of owning one's tasks as a means for employees to achieve motivation. By allowing employees to explore technology independently mangers could create opportunities such as a feeling of ownership over one's achievements and could therefore contribute to the employees' perceived motivation. However, the data conducted contrasts the literature by showing that autonomy on its own without support and structure from management can be viewed as a risk for creating uncertainty and challenges. Therefore, contribution to literature is made by suggesting that experimentation is a structured and supported process, rather than a self-learning one.

Additionally, while the participants in the finding show a positive attitude of wanting to implement digitalization, a challenge can be seen between the strategic advantage of digitalization and the practical understanding. According to Valtonen & Holopainen (2025, p. 49-50), a lack of experts' opinion and unclear dialog can be a reason for resistance from employees. Findings suggest that managers express frustration when top-management advocates for adoption of AI while lacking the practicalities of how it should be implemented. This means that decisions about digital implementation being taken with the belief to be a competitive advantage for the organization while risk creating internal challenges as no consideration is taken towards employees' interaction and acceptance to the digital tools. Mason & Nightingale (2026, p. 8-9) discuss that managers act like this due to reduced critical reflection and overreliance on data driven results. Therefore, decisions regarding digital transformation could be viewed as a balance between the encouragement of AI and critical reflection when favorable. At the same time, findings point out the need for human interaction and validation of generated results, showing that human judgment is still an affecting factor when making digital decisions. In this sense, findings contribute to the literature by demonstrating that successful implementation heavily relies on managers to convert strategic digital goals into understandable and

manageable practices. Thus, managers appear to occupy a complex intermediary role between strategic digital expectations and employees' operational realities.

5.2 Employee motivation, job satisfaction and employee performance

From an employee perspective, the findings demonstrated that digital transformation affected both motivation, job satisfaction, and performance. While many employees perceived digital tools as beneficial for both efficiency and work quality, some issues were also exhibited. Feelings such as uncertainty and overwhelming were apparent in the findings. Employees acceptance of digital technologies appears to be connected to how supported and capable they felt during the transformation.

The JD-R model states organizational support as a job resource that is a factor for engagement leading to motivation (Bakker et al., 2001, p. 501). One of the most prominent findings concerns the importance of managerial support in shaping employee perceptions toward digital transformation. Several of the employees highlighted managerial support in encouragement to use digital tools in their daily work. Another motivational factor appears to have been the opportunity to experiment and try out the new systems, where the findings suggest that some employees were given this possibility. Trenerry et al. (2021, p. 16) points out that exploring new digital tools in the learning process can be favorable for employee motivation. Adding further on previous research, employees seem to be more motivated when getting practical support and demonstrations, interacting with colleagues and management to learn rather than only theoretical briefings. Supportive managers therefore appear to be able to handle uncertainty and transform the work environment into a more secure place to adapt to technological changes.

At the same time, the employee's perception of support varied between the different organizations. *Ystad* described that there where *"no direct support"* from management. They were encouraged to attend conferences regarding AI but then left to figure out the operational part themselves, suggesting a possible gap between the organizational intentions and the employees' belief of the actual perceived support. Valtonen & Holopainen (2025, p. 49-50) explain that the user has to be able to understand the system they are operating for it to be a successful implementation. When the employees are left to handle unfamiliar systems on their own, there is a higher risk of resistance. Additionally, a self-learning mindset could also create some tension for the employees. Digital transformation could especially for new employees create a feeling of overstimulation. An employee explained that it can be problematic to navigate in the new systems and would therefore prefer clearer guiding for newcomers. Overload of information and uncertainty about digital tools is described as technostress and can be a contributing factor to loss of motivation and productivity (Tarafdar et al., 2007, p. 303 & 322). Further, Avtalion et al. (2025, p. 78993) adds that education regarding the new digital systems is an important factor for job satisfaction. To maintain or increase employees' job satisfaction, the findings add nuance by showing that stress is not only triggered by system complexity but also inconsistent management support. Leading to a contributing factor in the dimension of technostress in digital transformation.

Another finding was employees' perceived belief of increased efficiency and quality of their work through digital technologies. Most employees described the opportunity to

finish tasks significantly faster and could prioritize more valued and important tasks, leading to a feeling of improved quality of work. Aligning with the TAM-framework, Davis (1989, p. 320) where P*erceived Usefulness* explains that a new digital system is more likely to be accepted if an individual believes the system to enhance their work. From the data conducted employees appear to be more willing to use the digital systems when they believe the outcome to have an improvement on their workflow. *Perceived Ease of Use* is when the system is believed to take little effort, the usage from the employees will increase (Davis, 1989, p. 320). This was seen as less major; the employee's acceptance of the technologies was more in line with the feeling of simplifying tasks and reducing repetitive work. However, findings still suggest that ease of use is a significant factor in increasing acceptance.

Ullrich et al. (2023, p. 38) explains active participation can contribute to the employees' overall feeling of job satisfaction and well-being. Regarding how employees perceive managerial decision-making about digitalization, the findings point to employees seeing digital transformation as something decided from top-down and not something employees and middle management can affect. An employee explains the new systems as something that one just needs to accept. Indicating that the implementation could be seen as a process one could not participate in could potentially create a passive acceptance rather than actively advocating and being involved with the new digital transformation. Contributing further to active participation the indication of the employees believed involvement in the decisions regarding digital transformation could have and negative affect on employee's job satisfaction risking lacking engagement and possible resistance.

When discussing employee performance, earlier theories explain employee performance as driven by motivation, well-being, and organizational support (Hackman & Oldham, 1976; Bakker & Demerouti, 2007), the empirical findings demonstrate how these factors become even more critical during periods of technological change. In the findings, employee performance does not appear to have a direct correlation with digital transformation from the derived findings. Rather, it is seen as a final product from managers' decision-making about digital implementation. If the employees are satisfied and motivated, it will have a positive impact on employee performance. Thus, employee performance being the end result. Furthermore, findings suggest that digital transformation is not the direct driver of employee performance. Instead, it is influenced by how managers implement and support digital change. This contributed to previous research by highlighting the role of employee satisfaction, motivation, and engagement and its relation to digital transformation and performance by suggesting that technology only improves performance when employees feel supported, motivated, and accepting the changes.

The JD-R model emphasizes organizational resources such as autonomy, support, and feedback as important during digital transformation to enhance engagement and performance (Bakker & Demerouti, 2007). Empirical findings add to the theory by showing additional resources such as digital training, communication, learning opportunities, and managerial guidance is essential. In addition, Hackman and Oldham’s (1976) theory that the phycological states of meaningfulness and responsibility come to be challenged by the findings of this thesis. Employees stated that if they do not understand new systems or feel overwhelmed by technology, they tend to lose motivation and engagement.

Overall, a contribution is that the findings combine both positive and negative effects of digitalization. Prior research often shows either increased efficiency and productivity or highlighting the risks of technostress and overload. Through these findings, the perspective of the participants combines the good and the challenging parts by showing that the outcome depends on managerial commitment and employee acceptance of the transformation.

5.3 Discussion of contribution to previous literature

Digital transformation has reshaped the conditions under which managerial decision-making occurs. Prior research highlights that technological change increases digitalized decision-making that rely on data driven insights and AI generated recommendations (Guan et al., 2022). This shift challenges leadership frameworks and further struggles to explain how managers navigate rapid technological change (Cortellazo et al., 2019; Weber et al., 2022). Furthermore, less is known about how managers make decisions during digital transformation and how these affect employee well-being. The empirical findings contribute to this previously identified gap with managerial decision-making acts as a mechanism to implement digital systems. The findings suggested an essential explanation of how managerial decision-making in digital transformation affects employee motivation, satisfaction, and ultimately performance. The empirical findings in this study ultimate fill the gap by researching this topic amongst Swedish organizations as a considerate gap was seen in the Swedish Business Administration market. The Swedish context contributes insights into how digital transformation is managed in Swedish organizational cultures. The following sections will explore this further.

5.3.1 Managerial Support as a Mechanism for Employee Acceptance in Digital Transformation

The support of managers and the organization during a digital transformation proved to be essential across all three perspectives in the findings, where it was seen as a way to have a successful implementation. Findings showed the importance of support through a strategic and organizational perspective where communication regarding why, how, and for what an implementation is happening and needed for, whilst being transparent that a digital transformation may change certain tasks and will need time to adjust. Transparency gives reassurance and long-term cultural adaption.

This aligns with previous findings from Amoako-Gyampah and Salam (2003), which states the significance of managerial support in order to gain technological acceptance. This further contributes to the lack of integration in how decisions are made in digitalization highlighted in previous literature by Cortellazo et al. (2019) and Weber et al. (2022). Additionally, there is a shortage of integration between leadership and digital transformation, and how managers make decisions and lead in this transformation (Cortellazo et al., 2019; Weber et al., 2022). Empirical findings suggested that managers act as a bridge between top management's decision making regarding the implementation and employees' engagement to the systems. This study therefore contributes by demonstrating how managerial decision-making is operationalized in practice during digital transformation. The findings highlighted that being present, reassuring, encouraging experimentation, and guiding through uncertainty was how they interpreted support to their employees.

Cramarenco et al. (2023) and Stamante et al. (2021) discuss in their existing literature that a broader understanding of how digital technologies affect employee well-being and

possible complexity. The empirical findings from this study add to this understanding by visualizing how support is actually experienced in practice. The findings further suggest that while organizations show encouragement and support, it does not always match how employees recognize support. Support in practice is seen as easy access to the systems, training and guidance on how to work different systems, manager involvement through emotional reassurance.

5.3.2 Competence Development as a Link Between Strategy and Digital Execution

Li (2020) identified that a huge gap in research regards practical insights on how managers strategical decision-making in digital transformation is executed. The findings in this study aimed to fill this gap by moving beyond conceptual discussions by illustrating how employees and managers digital transformation in everyday organizational practice. The findings illustrated that when it comes to education about how the system works, the digital transformation will not work if organizations only give access to systems without giving training to how to use the digital tools. Without experts to educate with competence and training, it can lead to implementation resistance (Valtonen & Holopainen's, 2025). Findings showed that many organizations get stuck in their development as they give entry to systems without teaching employees how to use them effectively. Participants expressed in the findings of emerging gaps in the implementation where strategic and operational work does not match. Organizations and top management often encourage technology usage; however, managers are missing the explanation of how to use it. Through the findings it was seen that whilst most of the organizations have workshops and training sessions as an introduction to the systems, it could still be perceived, by the employees, as confusing to where to find further training and how to use certain systems. Overwhelming towards new systems being constantly implemented without proper and continues guidance was seen in the findings which highlights the complexity of how digital technologies negatively affect employee well-being that adds to previous researcher, Chaturvedi et al. (2025).

5.3.3 Structured Experimentation as a Contributor to Organizational Learning and Job satisfaction

An important aspect to think about that emerged from the findings is how essential it is to enable experimentation in digital transformation which directly links with the previous research from Brock and Khan (2017) that connect it with organizational learning capability. To build competence and acceptance amongst employees, it is necessary to make room and time for experimentation as it contributes to higher employee job satisfaction in digital transformation. This adds to the literature of Chiva et al. (2007) by showing that organizational learning capability in digital transformation strengthens job satisfaction not only through experimentation, but through structured managerial guidance and communication. Findings from across all three perspectives added that the time set for experimentation is seen as positive. However, only to a certain point, otherwise it could create too much self-learning without clear structure or managerial guidance. Experimentation should come with structure and clear communication.

5.3.4 Perceived Usefulness and Ease of Use as Drivers of Motivation and Performance

Previous literature (Yang et al., 2024; Li, 2020; Chiva et al., 2007) indicates that practical insights need to be done on managers digital decision-making and how it affects employee's motivation, job satisfaction, and performance. The empirical findings contribute to the previous literature by stating that digital tools increase efficiency, improve time management, and enhance the quality of work. It is shown how digitalization offers efficiency and when using it correctly, can increase work amount by more than double. Additionally, optimizing resources takes far less time to complete an assignment, which leaves room to focus on other more time-consuming tasks. This further aligns with TAM-framework developed by Davis (1989) that suggests perceived usefulness is what ultimately drives a user's acceptance. When a system is proven to contribute to an employee's work performance, it results in higher acceptance of digital technology. However, employees argue that depending on a system's complexity and understanding of it, it can either save time or be time consuming. Therefore, while perceived usefulness is what mostly determines acceptance, one cannot forget perceived ease of use meaning how easy it is to use a system, supporting TAM theory (Davis, 1989). Overall, these findings extend prior research (Yang et al., 2024; Li, 2020; Chiva et al., 2007) by suggesting that perceived usefulness and ease of use do not only drive technology acceptance but also indicates higher employee motivation and improved job satisfaction. When digital tools simplify work processes and improve task efficiency, employees are more likely to be motivated, have a greater sense of competence, and satisfaction in their work. The findings suggest that this will further increase employee performance.

5.3.5 Human oversight and Resistance in data-driven Decision-making

Findings from all three groups advocate for the positive effects of digitalization across an organizational level as well as employee level and performance, and that technology should act as a supporting tool and not a replacement for human judgment. Shalu et al. (2025) and Cortellazo et al. (2019) findings show that decision-making processes and how managers lead are different in digital transformation. Findings from this study emphasize critical thinking, quality checks, and that final decisions are still required to be made by humans. Furthermore, findings add that employees in practice are also needed to fact check what the system generates. At the same time as the participants are aware of human involvement is still viable; resistance can still be challenging toward digital transformation. Findings suggested different factors for resistance, some because of uncertainty or lack of competence in how to use the systems; others associated resistance with lack of proper implementation strategy. On the other hand, findings show that employees felt resistance to using the systems when it became overwhelming or felt no understanding of the decision-making process regarding the implementation. Overall, the findings contribute to literature (Shalu et al., 2025; Cortellazo et al., 2019) that organizational support, communication, and competence development all lead to higher acceptance and engagement amongst employees by integrating support and learning processes as joint mechanisms influencing botch acceptance and performance outcomes.

5.4 Summery of previous literature contribution

To summarize, the findings from this study suggest that managerial decision-making acts as a central mechanism on how employees experience digital transformation. While digital technologies can improve efficiency, performance, and job satisfaction, these outcomes largely depend on how managers implement, communicate, and support the

transformation process. The empirical findings extend previous literature by demonstrating that organizational support, competence development, structured experimentation, and transparent communication collectively influence employee acceptance and well-being, specifically motivation, job satisfaction, and performance during digital transformation. Furthermore, the study contributed practical insight into the Swedish organizational context, where managerial decision making decides, what managerial support is implemented to facilities employee acceptance and a successful digital transformation.

5.5 Findings connecting to conceptual framework

The analysis of the findings derived from three different perspectives: experts, managers, and employees and its contribution to the previous theory on how digital transformation can affect, in multiple ways depending on various factors, organizational outcomes and success. In this section, the empirical findings will be connected to the original conceptual framework and its basis on theory and previous research (see Figure 1). The conceptual framework visualizes how digital transformation (Valtonen & Holopainen, 2025) impacts managerial traditional process of decision-making (Simon, 1955; Pittenger et al., 2023; Neiroukh et al., 2025) and how those decisions shape managerial support that affect employee's acceptance to a system (Davis, 1989) in relation to employee well-being, specifically motivation, job satisfaction, and performance (Hackman & Oldham, 1976; Bakker et al., 2001; Locke, 1969; Motowildo et al., 1997).

All three groups of participants agree that decision making has changed with the implementation of digital transformation in organizations. Neiroukh et al. (2025) discussed how managers in digital times have more data to base their decisions on, contradicting the traditional way of the decision-making process that previously was based on solely human judgment, previous experiences, and intuition. Through the empirical findings from experts' perspective, we found that decisions are perceived as more reliable once they are based on actual data and facts. Experts discussed that it makes it easier to argument for a decision when you can back it up with data that arguments for why this decision is most beneficial. However, findings from experts stated that whilst decision-making through digitalization is faster and more consistent, it still is suggested to add a human perspective on it to fact check it. Managers' findings added that in the end, it is still a responsibility that falls under an individual who needs to take authority for it. This is added to the literature of Pittenger et al. (2023) arguing that managers face challenges as high amount of available data can cause overload, therefore managers making decisions have a need to balance digital decision-making and adapt it to the organization's long-term goals and in the best interest for their employees.

Furthermore, managerial decision-making impacts how managers choose how to support their employees in their process to accept the digital transformation, as it determines strategic, communication methods, and what resources are necessary. Empirical findings contributed to this by adding that managerial support is essential to either make or break digital implementation. Support from managers and the organization can help employees accept digital transformation by improving employee well-being. Employee perspectives in the empirical findings gave us insight into how managerial support contributed to their motivation in work as well as motivation to use the systems provided. This led to a higher level of job satisfaction, which increased employee performance. Organizational support is considered a job-resource that acts as an affecting factor to employee motivation related to their work (Bakker et al., 2001). Additionally, Locke (1969) describes job satisfaction as work that creates a positive emotion in alignment with one's personal beliefs, which

empirical findings across all three groups agreed on. Participants acknowledged how previous knowledge about technology influenced whether the implementation was accepted or rejected. On the other hand, in contradiction to the theory, we found that employee performance was seen as an end result of how all the previous variables acted and played out. Previous theoretical frameworks (Motowildo et al., 1997; Ismail & Muafi, 2019) argue that employee performance is the quality and quantity of achievements that an employee is required to complete, which leads to the overall performance of organizations. The thesis findings show that a more nuanced and clear structured implementation strategy should be worked on to further ensure a successful implementation, as without goals and vision digital transformation is more likely to fail. Further findings show that digital transformation impacts managerial decisions regarding how to support employee well-being thus leading to either their acceptance or rejection and depending on that, employee performance will either increase or decrease.

To summarize, the empirical findings through this study confirm and extend precious research on how digital transformation influences organizational outcomes (Valtonen & Holopainen, 2025). The findings demonstrate that digitalization reshapes managerial decision-making by increasing data access and provides faster decisions (Neiroukh et al. 2025), however, still requires human judgment as it is a human responsibility and creates strategic balance. Further, findings proved that managerial support has a significant role in determining whether digital transformation initiatives get accepted or rejected. Across all groups of participants, the empirical findings align with this thesis conceptual framework that supportive leadership, effective communication, and appropriate resources positively influence employee's motivation, job satisfaction, and acceptance (Hackman & Oldham, 1976; Bakker et al., 2001; Locke, 1969). The findings contribute to existing research by implying that employee performance should not only be viewed as part of employe well-being, but rather because of how managerial decisions, organizational support, employee acceptance, motivation, and satisfaction interact in the digital transformation process leading to improved employee performance. This phenomenon will be further studied in the revised conceptual framework. Additionally, the findings suggested a clear plan and execution of an implementation strategy is what determines the success of a digital transformation. More on this will also be explored in the revised conceptual framework.

5.6 Revised conceptual framework

The revised conceptual framework illustrates how digital transformation is not just a technological change, but also an interplay between managers and employees. Compared to the original framework, the revised version adds an *implementation strategy* as a central mechanism and moves *employee performance* as a final outcome. This reflects earlier decision-making theory where Simon (1955) and digital decision-making (Neiroukh et al., 2025; Pittenger et al., 2023) lead to managers operating under uncertainty and must adjust their decisions as new information and employee reactions emerge.

At the top of the framework is still *decision-making* and *digital transformation* regarding how managers make decisions based on today's digital transformation. However, through the findings it became apparent that decision-making highly influences what *implementation strategy* will be adapted. Through the findings, it was visualized that to make digital transformation a successful implementation managers need to have a clear strategy of how that should be implemented. Because of the study's methodologic choice

of an abductive approach, where the researcher goes back and forth between data and theory, it was apparent from the findings that implementation strategy was a key determinant. Thus, the revised conceptual framework adds the theory of Mintzberg's (1987) perspective that strategy and implementation continuously shape one another. Decisions shape implementation at the same time as implementation outcome also reshapes decisions. The empirical findings add that in the context of digital transformation, managerial decision-making influence the choice of which implementation strategy will be selected and how that will affect employee well-being, while employee well-being determines back how successful that implementation strategy becomes. Findings further show that managers influence decisions regarding implementation strategies through the way they implement and work with them. Strategies that include clear communication, employee participation, and sufficient support tend to improve employee well-being. Improved well-being then increases employee engagement, acceptance of change, and productivity which leads to enhanced success of the implementation strategy.

Mintzberg (1987) further visualizes strategy as multiple definitions that intercorrelate with each other, that is the Five Ps as a concept: *plan, ploy, pattern, position* and *perspective. Strategy as a Plan* explains the intended course of action as a set of guidelines and rules to follow for a specific situation, following two specific properties: it is developed in advance, and it is created with a goal (Mintzberg, 1987, p. 11). From the findings, the experts point out that a purposeful strategy is important when adapting digital transformation. Managers additionally add that top management's goal is to be technologically driven but without specifying how it will be accomplished while the employees explain a lack of certain guidelines. *Strategy as a Ploy* explains the importance of outwitting one's opponent, continuing with *Strategy as a Pattern,* that relies on the organization's actual behavior over time and not just the strategic plan (Mintzberg, 1987, p. 12-13). The findings of this study showed that digitalization is being implemented as its effectives in the organizations work which acts as a ploy. However, findings also suggest that most of them do not successfully implement strategy as a Pattern. The empirical findings demonstrate this by adding that strategy and practicality do not align. While top management often encourages technology and has given access to certain systems, it is not enough to reassure technology acceptance and use. *Strategy as a Position* is about placing the organization in contexts to its environment and findings its unique place (Mintzberg, 1987, p. 15). Lastly, *Strategy as a Perspective* looks into the organization, what characteristics and values they provide (Mintzberg, 1987, p. 6). Mintzberg (1987) underlines that these five definitions complete each other and by using all five definitions one could better understand the complex processes that evolve during formation of a strategy. From the findings, it is derived that managers need to formulate a well-rounded decision regarding the strategy of digital implementation while keeping employee work related well-being in mind, as well as making sure employee understand the decision being made and get them going on the systems. Therefore, the revised conceptual framework adds *implementation strategy* to visualize the findings regarding how digital systems are integrated in the daily work process.

At the core of the framework is still *employee well-being* with the focus on motivation and job satisfaction as key factors influencing the success of digital transformation and demonstrating that employee well-being is a central factor whether a digital transformation succeeds. This is because digital transformation introduces organizational and technological changes that can either enhance or reduce employee's effectiveness in

work. The empirical findings indicate managerial support in the form of communication, transparency, and practice hands-on learning plays a crucial role in shaping employees' motivation to use the systems and ensure satisfaction with their work. Further, findings show that by reducing uncertainty employees are more willing to adopt new digital systems and contribute to effective implementation. Thus, indicating that employee well-being is highly dependent on what type of managerial support employees receive through which digital transformation success is achieved.

The framework further demonstrates how *managerial support* and *employee technology acceptance* continuously influence each other. *Managerial support* affects how employees adapt and utilize digital tools while *employee technology acceptance* changes how managers make decisions in supporting employees. Through the finding, it was visualized that manager relies on digital tools and data driven decisions but still needs to consider human judgement to finalize the decisions for employee's benefits.

Lastly, the empirical findings highlighted that *employee performance* should be viewed as an end result of the entire process. This is because the findings show that managers' implementation strategies and support affect employee motivation and job satisfaction, which then in turn influence employee performance. In other words, the study found that employee performance is the outcome of a chain of influences. Digital transformation affects how managers make decisions to ensure the correct way to support employees. These management approaches influence employee motivation and job satisfaction, which then improve employee performance when using digital tools in a correct and effective way. As a result, effective managerial support and implementation strategies during digital transformation can lead to higher employee performance indirectly through improved employee attitudes.

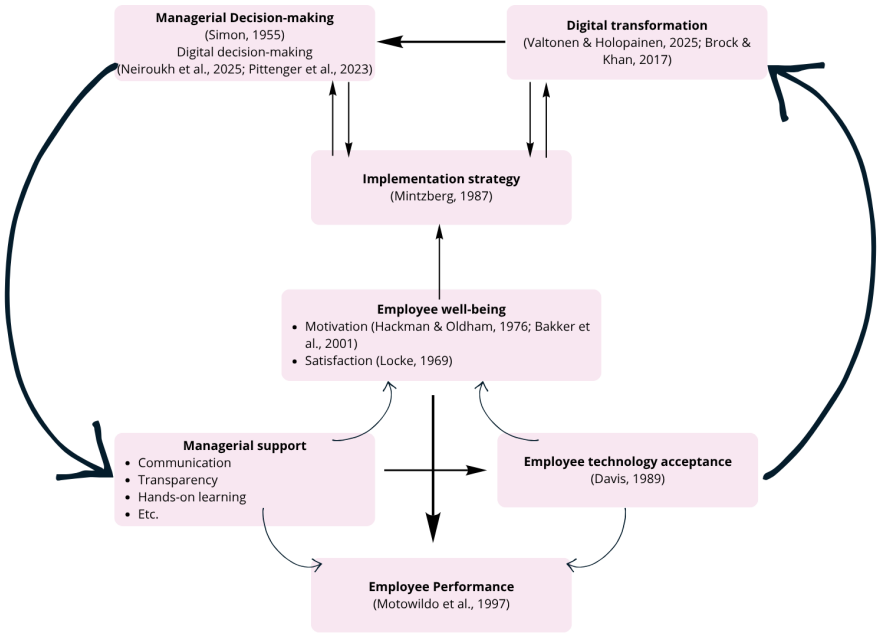


Figure 3. Revised conceptual framework

6. Conclusions

This chapter concludes the key insights from the empirical findings as well as the analyzation and discussion chapter. Further, the following sections aim to revisit the research purpose as well as the research question for a nuanced answer to be given. Additionally, this chapter concludes limitations of the study, theoretical and practical contributions, implications, and a discussion on suggestions for future research.

6.1 Conclusions of Key insights

Conclusions will be drawn from key findings in the empirical findings and will be revised to the study's purpose and research question. Building on the studies foundation, it will further be connected to theoretical frameworks and previous research retrieved from chapter 2, to provide a broader understanding of the empirical findings and their implications. An answer to the purpose and research question of this study will be discussed in the following sections.

6.1.1 Key findings

From interviews with experts, managers, and employees across five different organizations (Lyckeby, Trelleborg, Simrishamn, Ystad, and Kivik) insightful findings were able to be drawn on how digital transformation can be successfully implemented in an organization and prevent rejection from employees. Primarily, the study demonstrated that successful digital transformation is not solely dependent on technology itself, but on how organizations manage the human aspects surrounding its implementation. Managers therefore play a critical role in balancing data-driven decision-making with human-centered leadership to ensure both employee well-being and long-term organizational performance. Rather than replacing employees, digitalized systems should be seen as an assisting tool and with continued learning, support, and communication it can be successfully adapted. Additionally, findings show that the process of integrating and applying digital transformation should revolve around organizational long-term strategic visions and goals, because if it's embedded in the organization, it becomes part of the work culture and managerial decisions can be understandable to employees. The strategic decisions taken by managers should furthermore include employee well-being and how they will be affected by digital implementation, as employees play a significant role in how successful an implementation will be. If employees do not understand the reasoning behind the decisions being made in the organization or how to use the systems, they will most likely end up resistance to the transformation, thus leading to a failed implementation.

This leads us to another important finding, namely that implementation strategy is more than planning and implementing. It is more about continuously adapting the digital transformation process in relation to maintaining employee’s well-being and organizational long-term goals. The findings suggest that implementation is not a linear process where managers only introduce new systems and for employees to learn themselves, it is a process where managerial decision-making, employee responses, and organizational outcomes influence each other. With clear guidance, involvement, managerial support, and communicative adaption processes, it creates a bigger opportunity for successful implementation.

A critical finding that was able to be drawn concerns the future labor and job market in relation to the rapid change and evolvement of technology. As digitalization has continued to develop, it has raised the question about how much digitalization will affect organizations and if human judgment, experience, and capabilities may be replaced altogether. The empirical findings derived from this thesis contribute by expanding the understanding of how both digitalization and human are needed to deliver quality results efficiently. Instead of looking at them as substitutes, findings suggest that viewing them as complementary components that are necessary for organizational success. Although digitalization increases efficiency, automate certain tasks, improve productivity, and support decision-making through factual data, the empirical findings suggest that human involvement is still essential for delivering quality results. Critical thinking, ethical judgment, adaptability, and creativity are some of the qualities the participants argued cannot be replaced. This is also an important factor that affects employee well-being, as employees still get to feel included and contribute to their organizations. Further, the findings show that technology does not automatically improve employee performance. Rather, employee performance is affected by how organizations and managers implement digital transformation and support employees throughout the process. In this sense, digital transformation does not eliminate the need for human judgment but instead changes how human capabilities are needed in organizations. This is central to maintaining employee performance, organizational effectiveness, and long-term sustainability.

To summarize, the findings of this study illustrate that within the context of digital transformation, managerial decision-making and support plays a central role in shaping and maintaining employee well-being and ultimately the success of organizational implementation processes.

6.1.2 Revisiting the research purpose

The purpose of this thesis is to examine how managers balance and maintain digital transformation and employee well-being and their influence on employee motivation, job satisfaction, and performance. Additionally, develop a framework for managers to implement a successful digital transformation that supports organizational goals and employee effectiveness. Through the data collection, empirical findings explained how managerial actions determine that specific outcome.

A conceptual framework was therefore able to be developed to support organizations and managers in their digital transformation and enable a successful implementation were employee motivation and job satisfaction is enhanced thus leading to technology acceptance and improved employee performance. The framework acts as a guide and demonstrates that managers' importance of balancing digital transformation and employee well-being through implementation strategy, organizational support, communication, training, and employee involvement. While digital tools improve efficiency and decision-making, their impact on employee motivation, job satisfaction, and performance depends on how managers structure and support the transformation. The conceptual framework helps further answer the research purpose by showing that managers have a key role in developing a successful digital transformation as well as maintaining and improving the well-being of employees.

6.1.3 Answering the research question

The central research question that guided this thesis was: "*During digital transformation, how does managers' decision-making affect employee motivation, job satisfaction, and performance?".* Based on the semi-structured interviews derived from two experts' perspective, two managers from different companies, and their five employees, empirical findings suggest that managerial decision-making in digital transformation affects employee motivation, job satisfaction, and performance through the way managers implement, communicate, and support digital changes within the organization. Previous research has studied the technological aspect of digital transformation and its organizational outcome an identified research gap on how managers' decision-making influence employee well-being during digital transformation. This study's findings show that it is not merely digitalization itself affecting employee outcome, it is managers' decisions regarding implementation strategy, organizational support, communication, training, and employee involvement that shape employee acceptance or rejection.

The findings highlight that managerial decision-making affects employees through implementation strategy. Managers' strategic decisions regarding communication, training, experimentation, support, and organizational culture determine how digital systems are integrated into employees' daily work. These findings contribute to existing literature by addressing the limited focus on managerial implementation strategies within digital transformation research, showing that implementation strategy is one of the linkages of digital transformation and employee outcomes. Successful implementation strategies appear to balance technological goals with employee well-being, while unsuccessful strategies could potentially be a cause of uncertainty and resistance. Additionally, this suggests that managerial decision-making in digital transformation is not solely about increasing efficiency through technology, but also about balancing data-driven decision-making with human oversight and employee-centered leadership.

Findings further reveal that managerial decision-making in digital transformation can either make employees feel encouraged or overwhelmed during digital transformation. An aligning finding with previous research is managers who provide guidance, transparency, reassurance, and opportunities for experimentation to create conditions where employees feel more motivated to use new systems. When employees felt practical support, learning opportunities, and understanding, the purpose behind the implementation strengthened their motivation and willingness to engage with digital tools. In contrast, findings showed that lack of guidance, unclear expectations, or having to figure the systems out for oneself lead to uncertainty and resistance, reducing motivation. Thus, managerial decision-making could affect employees' motivation through the level of support and structure provided during implementation.

Regarding employee job satisfaction, empirical findings show that when employees' satisfaction is closely connected to how included, supported, and valued they feel during digital transformation. Digital tools that improve efficiency, reduce repetitive tasks, and enhanced work quality proved to give employees' higher sense of job satisfaction. However, findings suggested that satisfaction was dependent on employees understanding the systems and receiving sufficient support, through training, encouragement, and time for experimentation to use them effectively. Adding to prior theories, transparent communication and involvement in the transformation process contributed positively to employees' feelings of reassurance and meaningfulness, creating higher satisfaction in the workplace. On the other hand, when digital transformation was considered top-down, unclear, or overwhelming, employees described feelings of stress, frustration, and reduced satisfaction. Therefore, managerial decision-making influences

job satisfaction by the consequences of and whether digital transformation acts as supportive and meaningful or stressful and uncertain.

Employee performance proved to be a result of how managerial decisions shapes employee motivation, job satisfaction, and acceptance of digital transformation. Instead of a direct outcome of digitalization itself. While digital tools were perceived to increase efficiency, improve time management, and enhance work quality, these positive outcomes only occur when employees felt supported, motivated, and capable of adapting to the technologies. These findings therefore extend previous theories on employee performance by addressing the narrow understanding of managerial decision-making affect employee acceptance during digital transformation, demonstrating that digital transformation creates conditions where managerial support and implementation strategy becomes even more significant for maintaining performance.

Overall, this research suggests that managerial decision-making in digital transformation significantly affects employee motivation, job satisfaction, and performance through the implementation process. By exploring the limited research on the managerial and employee dimensions of digital transformation, it was found that managers influence employee outcomes by shaping organizational support, communication, training, transparency, and opportunities for involvement. In summary, the success of digital transformation depends less on the technology itself and more on how managers strategically implement digital transformation to maintain employees' well-being.

6.2 Theoretical contribution

Previous research by Neiroukh et al. (2025) explains that digitalization increases managers' access to information, data, and analytical tools thus enabling faster and more data driven decisions. From the empirical findings, an important theoretical contribution was the expanded understanding of this literature. The findings support this perspective as it showed that digital systems supported decisions and were perceived as easier to justify and more strategically grounded. However, the findings contribute further by adding that managerial decision-making is not seen as purely automated. Participants across all groups emphasized that human judgement remains necessary to interpret, validate, and contextualize digital outcomes. This contributes to the literature by suggesting that digital transformation does not replace managerial authority and responsibility, rather reshapes the process. Additionally, the thesis found that human judgment remains important despite the increasement of digitalization. While digital systems improve efficiency, findings suggest that fast-checking, contextual understanding, ethical reflections, and critical thinking are still important. Thus, the study contributes further to theory by stating that future digital workplaces are rather than replacing human judgment with technology; it should be seen as an assisting hand to humans.

One important theoretical contribution concerns the identified gap between strategic digital ambitions and practical implementation. The findings reveal that organizations and top management often promote digital transformation and AI adaption as strategic goals without clearly explaining how these systems should be implemented operationally. This contributes to existing theory by extending Mintzberg's (1987) perspective that strategy and implementation continuously shape one another. The findings demonstrate that digital transformation can not only be an organizational goal without practical implementation strategies connected to employees' daily work. This study contributes by showing that implementation strategy functions as a missing link between strategic

decision-making and successful digital transformation. Further, findings expand previous research by enhancing by suggesting that implementation failure is not only connected to technology itself, but also by insufficient communication, lack of competence training, unclear guidelines, and weak organizational support. This highlights the fact that strategic intentions are not alone enough for successful implementation, rather a combination of digital goals and practices regarding employee well-being.

Additionally, the findings of this study contribute to the JD-R model (Bakker et al., 2001; Bakker & Demerouti, 2007) by identifying additional transformation-related resources such as digital training, competence development, transparency, experimentation time, communication, and implementation guidance. Further, the findings show new job demands including uncertainty, information overload, continued adaptation, and technostress. To maintain employee motivation, job satisfaction, and performance findings suggest managers balance these demands with organizational support and resources.

The revised conceptual framework of this study acts as an important theoretical contribution. By visualizing how managerial decision-making regarding strategical and operational implementation effect the managerial support influencing employee technological acceptance, thus determining employee motivation and job satisfaction that leads to increased employee performance. Furthermore, the revised conceptual framework adds to the understanding of how managerial practices, technology adaption, and employee well-being connect and influence each other. It also offers guidance for future organizations wanting to implement digital transformation in a successful matter.

Lastly, this study contributes theoretically by providing a qualitative methodology to the already existing theoretical frameworks and research. This demonstrates an important contribution as it was highlighted as a significant research gap in the field as well as limited existence of it in the Swedish organizational market. Therefore, this study makes a theoretical contribution by filling the gap existing in the Swedish business sector market.

6.3 Practical contributions

Apart from the study's theoretical contributions, several practical contributions are also visible. The study incorporates perspectives from three different groups: experts, managers, and employees. Providing a nuanced understanding of how digital transition unfolds in practice and across different levels of hierarchy. While previous research has often examined digital transformations through its impact on the organization and the overall organizational performance, this study demonstrates the importance of researching how different perspective and levels of the organization are influenced by each other, to understand how digital transformation is handled in practice. Experts give us an understanding of how digital transformation should be approached, while managers showcase their understanding of how it is on an operational level, and lastly employees provide the insights of how it is perceived and accepted beyond strategical implementation.

The results of this study also appear to suggest that successful implementation requires more than the introduction of new tools; it visualizes a potential demand for structured and deliberate implementations strategies. The findings show that employees require clarity and reassurance in periods with digital change. Organizations could therefore strengthen their implementation of digital transformation by communicating clearly the

purpose of the transformation and the expected outcome to hinder uncertainty and resistance and help the employees understand the reason for the digital change. Further, a practical implication this study showcases is that in order to determine successful implementation, organizations need to provide their employees with the time to experiment with new digital tools. This could include interactive practical workshops where the employees can learn how to incorporate digital systems into everyday work tasks. More beneficially, it could also be done early in the process to increase the employees' feelings of contribution and their overall understanding of the change. The whole implementation could also be viewed as a step-by-step process where the employees experiment gradually before the entirety of the change is implemented. Additionally, since the study points to that managers act as intermediaries between digital strategies and employee outcome it could also show that managers need to receive training in digital decision-making and that the top managers also provide the managers with the mandate to adapt the implementation based on what the team needs. Therefore, this study practically contributes by visualizing the importance of allowing employees the time to experiment with digital tools to increase understanding to further work in an effective matter.

6.4 Societal and Ethical Implications

Looking into managerial decision-making during digital transformation and its effect on employee well-being, this study has several societal and ethical implications. From the empirical findings, a broader understanding of the impact managerial decision-making has on employee well-being was found.

An important social implication concerns employee's psychological well-being during organizational changes with digitalization. Indicating that organizational support is of the essence when adapting to new digital systems. Employees given the support they need can potentially contribute to their motivation and job satisfaction, which in turn could have an impact on the perceived contribution to the organization and the overall environment in the workforce. Thus, possibly generating an organization that is more motivated and content in which contributing to society. At the same time, insufficient support and unclear strategies can be a factor for uncertainty and stress. From the findings, employees express overwhelming and technostress when managing unfamiliar systems independently. Additionally, from an ethical perspective, the organization therefore has a part in the responsibility to ensure employees well-being with digital implementations to enable a safe work environment, rather than solely focusing on implementing digitalization for the benefit of achieving organizational goals.

Another important societal implication regards the importance of competence development and equal access to learning about the new digital systems. From the findings, it appears that employees that are given the opportunity to learn and experiment with the new systems are more likely to feel motivated and satisfied in their work. In contrast, insufficient training can affect employees that are more adapted to digital technologies compared to those who are not, perhaps generating a division between the groups. Which in turn can have an effect on the ease of implementing the digital transition. Overtime, this can affect workplace inclusiveness and the ability of different groups of society to adapt to new technology.

From an ethical perspective, the study emphasizes the responsibility organizations and managers have when implementing digital transformation. Since managerial decisions

directly affect employee motivation and job satisfaction, organizations have an ethical obligation to implement digital systems in a way that support employee well-being.

There is a potential overreliance on data driven decisions and AI generated results. On one hand, digital transformation can be viewed as a means for employees to increase their efficiency and time management one should be careful with not having too much dependency on digital tools. Excessive trust could lead to poor decisions affecting the quality of the outcome. This could lead to employees being frightened of being replaced and their skills not being needed, creating a general uncertainty in the work environment. Organizations need to ensure that digital technologies support human competence development and do not replace analytic thinking. The findings suggest that digital tools should be used as a supporting mechanism while still basing decisions on human expertise. Swedish organizations integrating digital processes are recommended to have this in mind to generate a fair working environment for employees. This creates both societal and ethical complications, as organizations carry a responsibility to implement digitalization while providing social sustainability and maintaining human capital.

6.5 Limitations

While this study contributes with insights regarding managerial decision-making in digital transformation and its effect on employee well-being, it still contains a few limitations that can be of influence of the empirical findings. Firstly, it is important to note that the study is conducted in a Swedish market and might therefore not manifest the same on different markets with another work culture. The study evolves findings with what Swedish employees consider important from managerial decision-making therefore based on the norms and practice visible in Sweden. As such, the transferability of the study to other geographical or culture contexts might be limited.

Continuously, it is essential to bring up the size of the research where the empirical data is gathered from a number of nine interviews, resulting in a relatively small sample size. Thus, constricting the generalizability of the study. The qualitative methodology chosen brings the subjective perception, making the findings exhibited in the data considerable context bound. The participants' individual experiences regarding digital transformation shape the analysis. The authors have put in effort to try to ensure credibility and transparency throughout the process that the subjective nature of the qualitative methodology might affect the replication of the study.

6.6 Future research

This study provides new insights on how managers balance digital transformation with employee well-being yet at the same time because of its scope and limitations some future research emerges. Firstly, the findings indicate that employees experience digital transformation differently depending on the individual. Future research should therefore examine digital transformation from an individual perspective focusing on personal characteristics such as age, prior technology skills, and their interest in the subject to further understand how those variables affect employee acceptance to new technology. This can have a significant influence on how it will further affect employee well-being.

Further, the study could expand the organizational perspective by conducting in-depth case studies of digital transformation initiatives in one organization at a time. By looking at top management, middle management, and employees from one and the same organization, it could enable researchers to analyze how digital transformation is

implemented across different organizations. This would also make it possible to investigate how digital transformation affects organizational performance and if well-being strengthened or hinders performance outcomes.

While this study focuses on employe well-being within organizational boundaries, future research could explore digital transformation and technologies such as AI from a broader social sustainability perspective. As these new technical changes can affect labor markets, further research could view how it can influence social inclusion and justice.

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Appendix

Medarbetare – svenska

Börja med detta: med digitala hjälpmedel och system så menar vi, all typ av digitalisering samt teknologi i arbetet. AI, co-pilt, Office, affärssystem, kundhanteing osv.

Teknologi

1. Kan du beskriva vilka digitala hjälpmedel som används och hur dessa används i organisationen?
2. Hur använder du dem i dina arbetsuppgifter?

Organisationen och chefernas roll

3. Hur introducerades det digitala systemet till organisationen?
4. Upplever du något stöd från cheferna i början av introduktionen?
    a. På vilket sätt?
5. Känner du att du får tillräcklig återkoppling av din chef?
    b. Bidrar det till motivation?

Beslutsfattande (Decision-making)

6. Hur har chefens beslut om digitala verktyg påverkat ditt sätt att fatta beslut i arbetet?
7. Känner du att du har mer eller mindre inflytande över beslut idag?

Acceptansen och användning av Digitala system (TAM)

8. Vilka faktorer påverkar din vilja för att använda digital systemet?
9. Upplever du att systemen är användbara i ditt arbete?
    a. På vilket sätt?

Arbetsprestation

10. Hur upplever du att din arbetsprestation har påverkats?
11. Har ditt arbete blivit mer eller mindre effektivt?
    a. På vilket sätt?
12. Påverkar verktygen kvaliteten på ditt arbete?
    b. Hur?

Välbefinnande (Motivation, job satisfaction)

13. Hur påverkar de digitala verktygen din stressnivå i arbetet?
14. Hur påverkar de din motivation eller engagemang i arbetet? /Upplever du att digitala hjälpmedel påverkar din motivation i arbetet?
    a. På vilket sätt?
15. Har din arbetsbelastning förändrats? Hur?
16. Hur påverkar arbetssättet dina relationer eller samarbetet med kollegor?
17. Upplever du dina arbetsuppgifter mer varierande eller samma?
    - Påverkar det hur engagerad du känner dig i ditt arbete?
    - Har arbetet blivit mer eller mindre stimulerande?

Employees – English

Start with this: by "digital tools and systems," we mean all forms of digitalization and technology used in the workplace, including AI, Co-Pilot, Office, business systems, customer management, and so on.

Technology

1. Can you describe which digital tools are used and how they are used in the organization?
2. How do you use them in your work tasks?

The organization and the role of managers

3. How was the digital system introduced into the organization?
4. Did you experience any support from managers at the beginning of the introduction?
    a. In what way?
5. Do you feel that you receive sufficient feedback from your manager?
    a. Does it contribute to motivation?

Decision-making

6. How have managers' decisions regarding digital tools affected your way of making decisions at work?
7. Do you feel that you have more or less influence over decisions today?

Acceptance and use of digital systems (TAM)

8. What factors influence your willingness to use the digital system?
9. Do you find the systems useful in your work?
    a. In what way?

Work performance

10. How do you perceive that your work performance has been affected?
11. Has your work become more or less efficient?
    a. In what way?
12. Do the tools affect the quality of your work?
    a. How?

Well-being (motivation, job satisfaction)

13. How do the digital tools affect your stress levels at work?
14. How do they affect your motivation or engagement at work? / Do you feel that digital tools influence your motivation at work?
    a. In what way?
15. Has your workload changed? How?
16. How does the way of working affect your relationships or collaboration with colleagues?
17. Do you experience your tasks as more varied or the same?

a. Does this affect how engaged you feel in your work?

b. Has the work become more or less stimulating?

Chefer och Experter – Svenska

Börja med detta: med digitala hjälpmedel och system så menar vi, all typ av digitalisering samt teknologi i arbetet. AI, co-pilt, Office, affärssystem, kundhanteing osv.

Bakgrund

1. Hur länge har du arbetet i en beslutsfattande/ledande roll?
2. Vilka typer av digitala verktyg/hjälpmedel använder ni idag i er organisation?

Digitala system (Decision-making)

3. Hur använder du digitala hjälpmedel eller data när du fattar beslut? (All typ av beslut)
4. Kan du ge ett exempel på ett beslut där digitala verktyg spelade en viktig roll?
5. Upplever du att digitala system förbättrar kvaliteten på dina beslut? Varför / varför inte?
6. Hur har ditt beslutsfattande förändrats vid införing av digitala system? / Har det förändrats?

Organisationen och chefernas roll / Acceptansen och användning av Digitala system (TAM)

7. Hur introducerade ni det senaste digitala system in i organisationen?
    a. Hur gick processen till av den implementeringen? Workshops etc.
8. Vilken roll anser du som chef att du har vid dessa nya typer av implementering? Support etc.
9. Hur har reaktionerna från medarbetare sett ut när ni inför nya digitala lösningar?
10. Vilka faktorer anser du spelar stor roll vid dessa typer av implementeringar för att medarbetaren ska acceptera dem?
    a. Om medarbetaren skulle motstå nya digitala system vad tror du det beror?

Påverkan på medarbetare välmående

11. Upplever du att digitalisering påverkar dina medarbetare?
    a. På vilket sätt?
12. Hur arbetar du som chef för att bibehålla medarbetarnas motivation?
13. Hur har ditt arbete för att bibehålla medarbetarnas motivation förändrats efter införandet av digitalisering?
14. Som chef, finns det behov av att balansera medarbetarnas välmående och beslutsfattande för företagets bästa?
    a. Om ja – hur?
    b. Om nej - Varför inte?
15. Något mer du vill tillägga?

Managers and Experts – English

Start with this: by "digital tools and systems," we mean all forms of digitalization and technology used in the workplace, including AI, Co-Pilot, Office, business systems, customer management, and so on.

Background

1. How long have you worked in a decision-making/leadership role?
2. What types of digital tools or systems are currently used in your organization?

Digital Systems (Decision-making)

3. How do you use digital tools or data when making decisions? (all kinds of decisions)
4. Can you give an example of a decision where digital tools play an important role?
5. Do you feel that digital systems improve the quality of your decisions? Why / why not?
6. How has your decision-making changed with the introduction of digital systems? / Has it changed?

The Organization and the Role of Managers / Acceptance and Use of Digital Systems (TAM)

7. How did you introduce the most recent digital system into the organization?
    a. How did the implementation process take place? Workshops, etc.
8. What role do you believe you have as a manager when implementing these types of new systems? Support etc.
9. How have employees reacted when new digital solutions are introduced?
2. What factors do you believe are important for employees to accept these types of implementations?
    a. Do you think it affects their motivation?

Impact on Employee Well-Being (Motivation, job satisfaction, performance)

3. Do you feel that digitalization affects your employees?
    a. In what way?
4. How do you work as a manager to maintain employees' motivation?
5. How has your work to maintain employees' motivation changed after the introduction of digitalization?
6. As a manager, do you see a need to balance employee well-being with decision-making for the benefit of the company?
    b. If yes – how?
    c. If not, why not?
7. Is there anything else you would like to add?



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